

U.S. National Science Foundation

BRAND STANDARDS MANUAL

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NSF Brand Standards Manual

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INTRODUCTION

The U.S. National Science Foundation Brand Standards Manual

About NSF

Using NSF's Logo



Introduction

The U.S. National Science Foundation Brand Standards Manual

The following pages outline a unified framework to support the agency's written, verbal and visual identity. Appropriate and consistent brand application strengthens the U.S. National Science Foundation's integrity, recognition and professionalism as a federal agency and awareness of our work, which results in taxpayer and congressional support for publicly funded science. The U.S. National Science Foundation Office of Legislative and Public Affairs (NSF OLPA) manages the brand identity for the agency.

The following guidelines provide information on appropriate usage of NSF's brand identity and implementation of the [***NSF Policy on Brand Standards***](#).

For questions regarding use of NSF's brand identity, email [***NSFbranding@nsf.gov***](mailto:NSFbranding@nsf.gov).

For resources, including those discussed in this manual, visit the [***NSF Brand Identity Portal***](#).

! THE U.S. NATIONAL SCIENCE FOUNDATION BRAND STANDARDS MANUAL IS DESIGNED TO BE AN INTERACTIVE EXPERIENCE.

For easy reference, the [***Table of Contents***](#) is hyperlinked to the referenced pages and can easily be returned to by the Table of Contents box in the lower-right hand corner. Hyperlinks, section references and emails are also clickable throughout content.



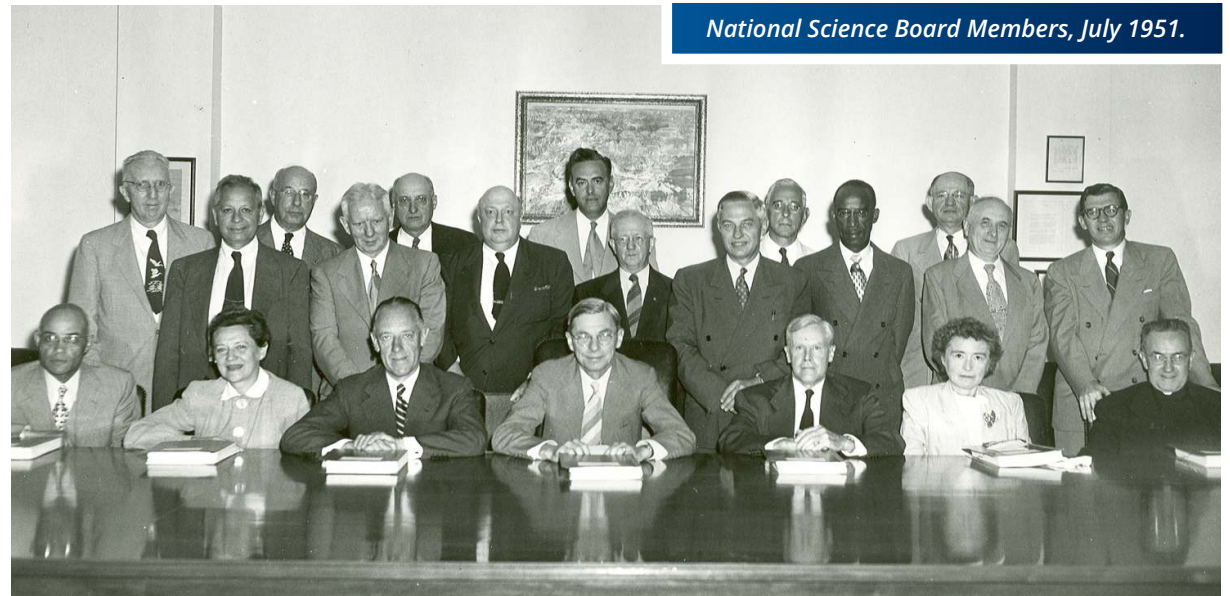
Introduction

About NSF

The U.S. National Science Foundation is an independent federal agency created and funded by Congress in 1950 *“to promote the progress of science; to advance the national health, prosperity, and welfare; to secure the national defense...”*

America’s economic and national security depend on NSF’s ability to invest heavily in the technologies of today while making the discoveries that are the foundation for the technologies of tomorrow.

NSF investments account for about 25% of federal support to America’s colleges and universities for basic research: research driven by curiosity and discovery. NSF also supports solutions-oriented research with the potential to produce advancements for the American people.



National Science Board Members, July 1951.



The Milky Way Galaxy is seen over the NSF Karl G. Jansky Very Large Array west of Socorro, New Mexico.



Introduction

About NSF

“Where discoveries begin”

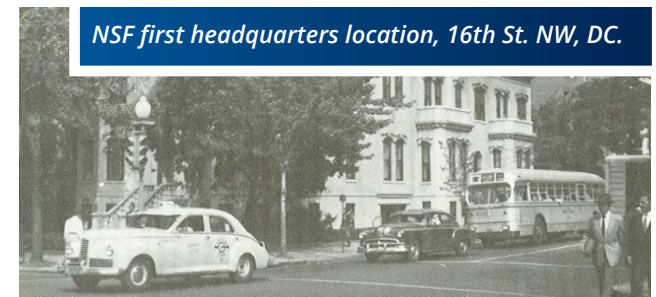
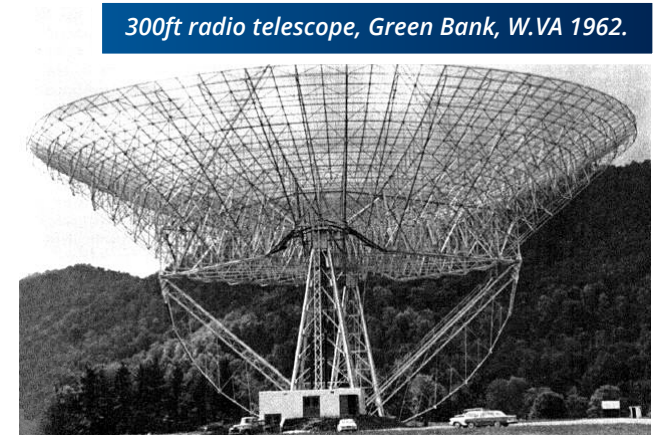
NSF's goals—discovery, learning, research infrastructure and stewardship—provide an integrated strategy to advance the frontiers of knowledge, cultivate a world-class, broadly inclusive science and engineering workforce and expand the scientific literacy of all citizens, build the nation's research capability through investments in advanced instrumentation and facilities, and support excellence in science and engineering research and education through a capable and responsive organization.

We like to say that NSF is **“where discoveries begin.”**

Many of the discoveries and technological advances have been truly revolutionary.

NSF's investments have made revolutionary discoveries and advances possible for 75 years. NSF-invested researchers have won 236 Nobel Prizes as well as countless other prestigious awards. Most importantly, though, NSF investments have improved the lives of all of us.

Visit www.nsf.gov/impacts to see some of the ways NSF has invested in ideas and innovations that have shaped the modern world.



U.S. National Science Foundation logo evolution, 1950—2022.*

*For informational purposes only



Seals and logos of the federal government are not in the public domain. As such, use of the NSF logo may only be used as authorized by the agency. Use of government names, symbols, logos and other identifying marks, including the NSF logo, are expressly prohibited from use to imply endorsement of a commercial product or service. These logos and marks are designed to signify official agency products, communications, activities, representatives, facilities and awards. They must never be used by outside parties to misrepresent the purpose, character, statements or policies of agencies.

- ▶ NSF's logo **can** be used by NSF staff for brand application on official communications and materials.
- ▶ NSF's logo **can** be used by NSF award recipients for the sole purpose of acknowledging that support consistent with the [***NSF Proposals and Award Policies and Procedures Guide \(NSF PAPPG\), Chapter XI E 4***](#) and this manual.
- ▶ NSF's logo **can** be used by institutions of higher education when promoting information related to NSF funding opportunities.
- ▶ NSF's logo **can** be used to link to an NSF website or acknowledge NSF assistance or affiliation with NSF approval by submitting a request to NSFbranding@nsf.gov.
- ▶ NSF's logo **cannot** be used in a manner that falsely implies employment by or affiliation with NSF.
- ▶ NSF's logo **cannot** be used to promote or imply endorsement of a product, service or enterprise.

Use of the NSF logo on content that could require viewer discretion due to inclusion of language, substances, nudity, sex, violence, political or controversial issues must be reviewed and approved by NSF OLPA by emailing NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

Anyone who meets the stated conditions above for using the NSF logo must follow the guidance for proper logo application. No other potential uses of the NSF logo are permitted unless prior written consent is obtained from NSF OLPA.

All use and reproduction of the NSF brand identity must comply with the design guidelines in this manual.

Any use of the NSF logo on any materials, regardless of whether produced by NSF or an outside entity for use in an NSF-associated activity, may be subject to prior review and approval as specified in this manual or otherwise requested by NSF OLPA to ensure consistency with the guidelines. General communication materials with allowable and/or required use of the NSF logo do not inherently necessitate review unless specified.

Reference the [***Logo Use by Partners and Others***](#) section for additional logo use requests.



BRAND IDENTITY ELEMENTS & APPLICATION

NSF Logo

Font & Font Usage

NSF Primary & Secondary Color Palette

USWDS Color Palette



Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Logo

Logo elements

The logo of the U.S. National Science Foundation features the NSF acronym on a globe backdropped by a medallion. The NSF logo is the sole visual identifier of the U.S. National Science Foundation and embodies a set of values that is applied to everything created and communicated.

! All logo use must follow specific production requirements and must not introduce individual design preferences. The NSF logo must be present on all external and internal communications.

The core of NSF's visual identity consists of the three elements below.

Medallion

The medallion on the NSF logo represents the “gold standard” that NSF sets in its merit review process of scientific proposals.

Globe

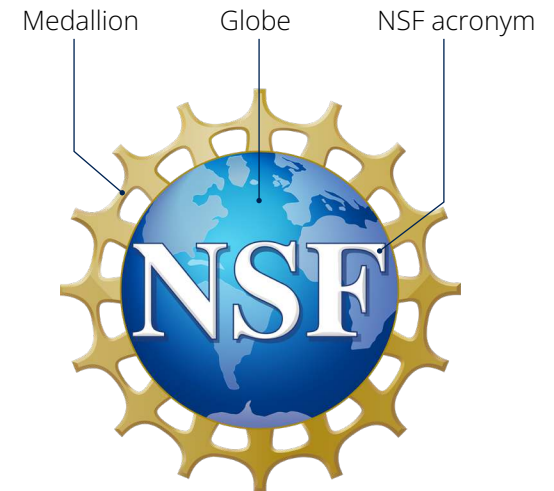
The globe represents the domestic and global reach of the impacts that result from NSF-invested research across all fields of science.

NSF acronym

The letters N-S-F create the acronym for the U.S. National Science Foundation.

Other visual brand elements

The second and equally important part of NSF's identity is the agency name. “U.S. National Science Foundation” must be spelled out and used in tandem with the NSF logo. These two elements should be used together as much as possible. This can be achieved by using the standardized logo + text lockup designs created by NSF OLPA or by using separate header text.



U.S. National Science Foundation



Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Logo

Proper logo use

The NSF logo must never be combined with another logo or piece of artwork to create a new identity. Proper logo use in conjunction with an NSF affiliate or co-sponsor is outlined in the [Logo Usage by Partners and Others](#) section.

Prior versions of the NSF logo and elements of them may be used only in historical context.

Proper use, placement, spacing and reproduction of the NSF logo always applies.

The NSF logo may only be used as permitted for purposes described in this manual or by special approval by submitting a request to NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

Incorrect NSF logo use

The NSF logo must not be altered or distorted in any way. The effectiveness of the logo and NSF brand integrity depends on consistency of usage.

The last example shows both correct and incorrect logo use with an NSF affiliate. NSF-developed templates are available on the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#) which adhere to proportion and sizing requirements. The logo must also not be used multiple times on the same surface or page.

The open/clear space rule applies always, as shown in the [Clear Space](#) section.

The logo must never be re-proportioned, distorted or set at an angle.



The logo must never be disassembled and used as separate elements, re-typeset using another font or be re-colored.



The logo must never have artificial effects such as stroke, drop shadow, transparency, beveling, emboss or glow.



The logo must never be combined with another logo or piece of artwork to create a new identity.



Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Logo

Primary logo

The primary NSF logo is a full color logo with highlights, shading and dimensionality. It is the core component of NSF's brand identity, creates a distinctive graphic presence for the agency and serves as a visual signature. ***The primary logo must be used on all internal and external NSF communications and graphic designs whenever possible.*** Logo variants may be used when use of the primary logo is not feasible because of size limitations or production requirements. Logo variants have specific use cases that are detailed in this section and must not be used based on artistic preference.

Prior versions of the NSF logo, and elements of them, may be used only in historical context.

Logo files

The NSF primary logo is available in multiple file types and color spaces and is intended to be utilized for different purposes.

Primary logo files

The NSF primary logo is available in multiple file types and color spaces which are intended to be utilized for different purposes. Primary logo files are available in both raster and vector formats. Raster file formats, such as PNG files, are used in most design cases. Vector file formats, such as EPS files, are typically used for print, production and large-scale reproductions.

► PNG files

Most users will use PNG logo files. PNG logo files are similar to JPG image files but retain a transparent background. PNG files also employ lossless compression, so an image can be resaved multiple times without causing further degradation of image quality. All PNG files are in the RGB color space.

There are two vector files of the primary logo design available on the [***NSF Brand Identity Portal***](#):

► CMYK EPS vector file

Use only when the primary intended production is professional printing and when working with outside vendors.

► RGB EPS vector file

Use in all other scenarios when a vector file is required.



Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Logo

! If a vendor only provides specific options, please work with NSF Brand Management to identify which colors are most suitable and closest match.

Additional logos

Four variants of the primary logo are available. All of these logos are available as vector files and PNGs, like the primary logo. Since these variants must only be used when necessary to meet specific production requirements, they will not be made widely available for download.

These logo files are available upon request from NSF OLPA by contacting NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

► Four-color logo without shading



This logo lacks highlights, shading and dimensionality in the medallion and acronym, and each component of the logo is a solid color. This logo is for limited use when only solid colors can be used in production, such as on patches or other embroidery where shading is not possible.

The color composition of the four-color vector NSF logo without shading, including Pantones, is outlined below and can be provided to an outside vendor when requested. Reach out to NSFbranding@nsf.gov with any Pantone questions, as the color accuracy may vary based on production method and vendor specifications.

NSF Blue Pantone 301 C		NSF Continent Blue Pantone 651 C		NSF Gold Pantone 8-6 C	
C: 100	R: 0	C: 39	R: 157	C: 0	R: 211
M: 60	G: 86	M: 25	G: 173	M: 14	G: 179
Y: 0	B: 153	Y: 3	B: 208	Y: 75	B: 78
K: 18		K: 0		K: 20	



Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Logo

Additional logos (continued)

► Grayscale logo

This is a limited-use logo and may only be used when materials are printed only in black and white and explicit permission is given from NSF Brand Management.

► One-color logo

This is a limited-use logo for one-color imprints, such as promotional items, and may only be printed in either black or white. The primary one-color logo with the continents depicted must be used in all instances when the logo is being reproduced with one ink at 5/8" or larger. The one-color vector logo must not be used on digital materials except when included in series of three or more one-color co-sponsor logos.

The simplified one-color logo may be sized smaller than the official NSF logo and is approved for use when production size is smaller than 5/8". In some additional production instances, the simplified NSF logo may be used, but only with explicit written permission granted by NSF OLPA.



Grayscale logo.



Primary one-color logo.



Simplified one-color logo.

Clear space

Proper use, placement, spacing and reproduction of the NSF logo must comply with guidelines outlined in this manual at all times.

To give it a place of prominence and isolation, the NSF logo must always be surrounded by a generous amount of open/clear space free of any text and distracting graphics or imagery. The example to the right shows the minimum amount of open/clear space around the logo. Since the size of the NSF identifier will vary depending on the application, use the guidelines below for how to determine the measurement for clear space. *The clear space must always be 1/8 of the NSF logo's width or height.*

Logo width/height	2" or 192px	4" or 384px	8" or 768px	16" or 1536px	32" or 3072px
Clear space on each side	1/4" or 24px	1/2" or 48px	1" or 96px	2" or 192px	4" or 384px



Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Logo

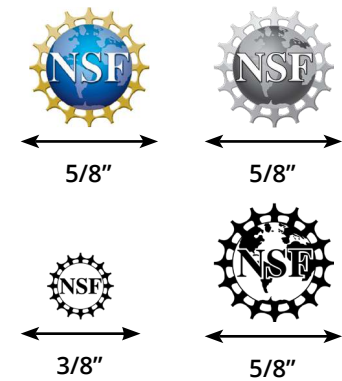
Minimum size

The minimum reproduction size of the NSF logo is based on both height and width because it is the same dimension all around. For full-color and grayscale logos, a minimum size of 5/8" (0.625 inch) must be used both in print and on the web. If the size is any smaller than the minimum, the logo loses its impact and artistic integrity. The primary one-color (with continents) can be sized down to a minimum of 5/8" (0.625 inch) and the simplified one-color (without continents) can be sized down to a minimum of 3/8" (0.375 inch).

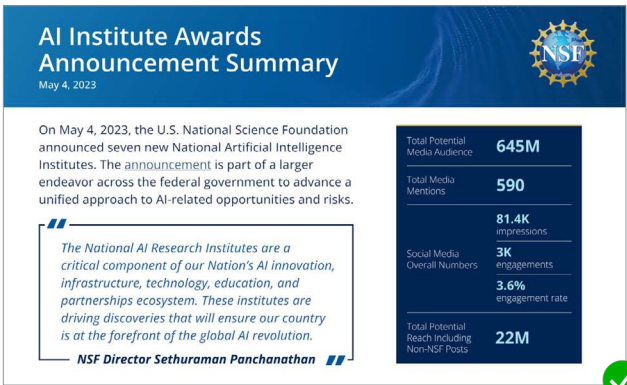
While these are the recommended size minimums, the logo must always be proportionate to and approximately 1/8 of the total height of the surface it is being placed on.

Use of imagery and backgrounds behind logos

Subtle and non-descript backgrounds may be used behind the logo, however there must always be enough color contrast between the logo and the background to satisfy 508 compliance requirements. The NSF logo must always maintain contrast and be legible and distinguishable. Gradients are approved for use as long as contrast with the logo is maintained. Do not use complex background patterns or images where the NSF logo is not clearly comprehensible.



Correct contrast with NSF logo.



correct

Insufficient contrast with NSF logo.



incorrect

Color settings

When designing products in Adobe software programs, set color settings for the file to **North America General Purpose 2**. Additionally, when possible, use **Adobe RGB** and monitor setting, **sRGB IEC61966-2.1**.



Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Logo

NSF logo text configurations

The official logo and text lockups can be configured in three ways: (1) with the text to the right of the logo (with text centered top to bottom); (2) with the text below the logo on one line (centered); or (3) with the text stacked to the right (with text centered top to bottom).

It must never appear with the text to the left of the logo, unless using the logo separately from header text. The single line text configurations are preferred. The text must be prominent, but it must not exceed the size of the letters in the logo. On darker backgrounds, the “U.S. National Science Foundation” text can be reversed to white to provide better contrast.

NSF has standardized logo lockups, and only the official versions should be used for the main agency lockups as well as NSF offices, directorates, divisions and programs.

These logo lockup files, as well as the reversed text variations, are available in the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#) or by request from NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

Text to the right configuration.



Text below (one line) configuration.



Text stacked to the right configuration.



Brand Identity Elements & Application

Font & Font Usage

Open Sans, a Google font, must now be used as the primary NSF font. Open Sans is an extensive font family, enabling communications to be dynamic while still maintaining typographic consistency.

Adherence to this policy strengthens our communications and ensures professionalism in all designed materials.

Adobe Garamond Pro is often used for titles and the text “U.S. National Science Foundation” when used with the logo. Adobe Garamond Pro is an acceptable alternative and is the font used in the official NSF logo plus text lockups. This font is a good alternative when a serif font is necessary.

NSF OLPA discourages utilizing the Calibri font. Calibri is overused as a default font and does not lend itself to creating a unique brand identity for NSF communications. It is preferred to use one of the other NSF font options for written documents, in addition to graphics.

! Incorporating the NSF color palettes and typography elements into all communications, both internal and external, is imperative to create consistent, professional and strong visual design.

Primary Typeface:



Open Sans Light
Open Sans Regular
Open Sans Semibold
Open Sans Bold
Open Sans Extrabold

Open Sans Light Italic
Open Sans Regular Italic
Open Sans Semibold Italic
Open Sans Bold Italic
Open Sans Extrabold Italic

Open Sans Light is not recommended for use in PowerPoint due to display issues.

Secondary Typeface:



Open Sans Condensed Light
Open Sans Condensed Light Italic
Open Sans Condensed Bold

Open Sans Condensed is not recommended for use in PowerPoint due to display issues.

Additional Typefaces:



Typeface for titles and text for “U.S. National Science Foundation”

Adobe Garamond Pro
Adobe Garamond Pro Italic
Garamond
Garamond Italic



Brand Identity Elements & Application

Primary & Secondary Color Palette with Tint Examples

NSF's color palette has expanded to include two primary colors from the original palette plus five secondary colors with tints and shades of each. The expanded palette allows for greater flexibility and creativity in communications while strengthening NSF recognition through visual consistency.

*Tints can range from 10% - 90%.
Examples of some tints are shown here.*

NSF Blue Hex: 005699 RGB: 0, 86, 153 CMYK: 100, 60, 0, 18	80% Hex: 4477A9 RGB: 68, 119, 169 CMYK: 78, 49, 13, 0	NSF Gold Hex: D3B34E RGB: 211, 179, 78 CMYK: 0, 14, 75, 20	80% Hex: DCC276 RGB: 220, 194, 118 CMYK: 15, 20, 67, 0
	60% Hex: 6799C0 RGB: 103, 153, 192 CMYK: 61, 30, 11, 0		60% Hex: E4D298 RGB: 228, 210, 152 CMYK: 11, 13, 48, 0
	35% Hex: A6C3DA RGB: 166, 195, 218 CMYK: 34, 14, 7, 0		40% Hex: EDE1BA RGB: 237, 225, 186 CMYK: 7, 8, 31, 0
	20% Hex: CCDDEA RGB: 204, 221, 234 CMYK: 18, 6, 4, 0		20% Hex: F6F0DC RGB: 246, 240, 220 CMYK: 3, 3, 14, 0

Light Green Hex: 00C37E RGB: 0, 195, 126 CMYK: 77, 0, 67, 0	Light Blue Hex: 4EC3E0 RGB: 78, 195, 224 CMYK: 60, 0, 2, 0	Teal Hex: 00758D RGB: 0, 117, 141 CMYK: 100, 0, 24, 30	Purple Hex: 473B70 RGB: 71, 59, 112 CMYK: 84, 87, 28, 14	Dark Blue Hex: 002554 RGB: 0, 37, 84 CMYK: 100, 73, 0, 61
80% Light Green Hex: 33CF97 RGB: 51, 207, 151 CMYK: 66, 0, 57, 0	80% Light Blue Hex: 71CFE6 RGB: 113, 207, 230 CMYK: 50, 0, 8, 0	80% Teal Hex: 3390A3 RGB: 51, 144, 163 CMYK: 78, 29, 31, 1	80% Purple Hex: 6C628C RGB: 108, 98, 140 CMYK: 65, 65, 23, 4	80% Dark Blue Hex: 335075 RGB: 51, 80, 117 CMYK: 88, 69, 32, 15
60% Light Green Hex: 66DBB1 RGB: 102, 219, 177 CMYK: 53, 0, 42, 0	60% Light Blue Hex: 94DBEC RGB: 148, 219, 236 CMYK: 38, 0, 6, 0	60% Teal Hex: 66ABBA RGB: 102, 171, 186 CMYK: 60, 18, 24, 0	60% Purple Hex: 9089A9 RGB: 144, 137, 169 CMYK: 47, 45, 18, 1	60% Dark Blue Hex: 667B98 RGB: 102, 123, 152 CMYK: 65, 47, 26, 3
40% Light Green Hex: 99E7CB RGB: 153, 231, 203 CMYK: 37, 0, 28, 0	40% Light Blue Hex: B8E7F2 RGB: 184, 231, 242 CMYK: 25, 0, 4, 0	40% Teal Hex: 99C7D1 RGB: 153, 199, 209 C: 39, 9, 15, 0	40% Purple Hex: B5B0C5 RGB: 181, 176, 197 CMYK: 29, 27, 11, 0	40% Dark Blue Hex: 99A7BA RGB: 153, 167, 186 CMYK: 42, 28, 18, 0
20% Light Green Hex: CCF3E5 RGB: 204, 243, 229 CMYK: 18, 0, 13, 0	20% Light Blue Hex: DBF3F8 RGB: 219, 243, 248 CMYK: 12, 0, 2, 0	20% Teal Hex: CCE3E8 RGB: 204, 227, 232 CMYK: 19, 3, 7, 0	20% Purple Hex: DAD7E2 RGB: 218, 215, 226 CMYK: 13, 12, 4, 0	20% Dark Blue Hex: CCD3DC RGB: 204, 211, 220 CMYK: 18, 11, 8, 0



Brand Identity Elements & Application

Primary & Secondary Color Palette With Shade Examples

Shades also apply to the NSF color palette and can be used on lighter backgrounds.

Different percentages for shades of secondary colors apply, 5% - 45% values only. The shades listed on the right are the official, approved shades for use in NSF materials.

! Additional colors can be incorporated to meet design needs as long as the NSF color palette is prioritized.

NSF Blue Hex: 005699 RGB: 0, 86, 153 CMYK: 100, 60, 0, 18	5% Hex: 005293 RGB: 0, 82, 147 CMYK: 99, 74, 15, 2	NSF Gold Hex: D3B34E RGB: 211, 179, 78 CMYK: 0, 14, 75, 20	5% Hex: C4AA4A RGB: 201, 170, 74 CMYK: 23, 29, 85, 1
	25% Hex: 00437B RGB: 0, 67, 123 CMYK: 100, 81, 26, 10		25% Hex: A68E3D RGB: 166, 142, 61 CMYK: 35, 38, 92, 7
	45% Hex: 0F325F RGB: 0, 50, 98 CMYK: 100, 86, 35, 26		45% Hex: 82702D RGB: 130, 112, 45 CMYK: 45, 46, 99, 20

Light Green Hex: 00C37E RGB: 0, 195, 126 CMYK: 77, 0, 67, 0	Light Blue Hex: 4EC3E0 RGB: 78, 195, 224 CMYK: 60, 0, 2, 0	Teal Hex: 00758D RGB: 0, 117, 141 CMYK: 100, 0, 24, 30	Purple Hex: 473B70 RGB: 71, 59, 112 CMYK: 76, 100, 0, 18	Dark Blue Hex: 002554 RGB: 0, 37, 84 CMYK: 100, 73, 0, 61
5% Light Green Hex: 33AF76 RGB: 51, 175, 118 CMYK: 75, 4, 72, 0	5% Light Blue Hex: 4BB9D5 RGB: 75, 186, 213 CMYK: 63, 6, 12, 0	5% Teal Hex: 007088 RGB: 0, 112, 136 CMYK: 89, 45, 36, 9	5% Purple Hex: 44386B RGB: 68, 56, 107 CMYK: 85, 88, 30, 17	5% Dark Blue Hex: 14244D RGB: 20, 36, 77 CMYK: 100, 91, 39, 39
25% Light Green Hex: 269363 RGB: 38, 147, 99 CMYK: 81, 19, 78, 4	25% Light Blue Hex: 3E9BB3 RGB: 62, 155, 179 CMYK: 73, 23, 24, 0	25% Teal Hex: 005C70 RGB: 0, 92, 112 CMYK: 93, 54, 42, 19	25% Purple Hex: 352956 RGB: 53, 41, 86 CMYK: 89, 92, 36, 31	25% Dark Blue Hex: 031138 RGB: 3, 17, 56 CMYK: 100, 92, 43, 57
45% Light Green Hex: 14754E RGB: 20, 117, 78 CMYK: 87, 30, 82, 18	45% Light Blue Hex: 2D7C8F RGB: 45, 124, 143 CMYK: 82, 39, 35, 5	45% Teal Hex: 004758 RGB: 0, 71, 88 CMYK: 95, 62, 48, 34	45% Purple Hex: 241840 RGB: 36, 24, 64 CMYK: 91, 95, 41, 49	45% Dark Blue Hex: 000020 RGB: 0, 0, 32 CMYK: 85, 80, 57, 76



Brand Identity Elements & Application

USWDS Color Palette

NSF created color palettes for internal users, which are listed in both this manual as well as the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#). An NSF color palette conversion to U.S. Web Design System (USWDS) system color tokens is available for download.

The NSF color palette conversion to USWDS system color tokens was developed for and in collaboration with the NSF web teams. Additional information on usage, instructions and how to use the design tokens can be found on the [website](#).

NSF USWDS color token conversions.

NSF Color Palette conversion to U.S. Web Design System (USWDS) System color tokens

USWDS system color tokens are the complete palette of color tokens from which any project can build a theme palette.

<https://designsystem.digital.gov/design-tokens/color/system-tokens/>

Hex: 005ea2
R: 0, G: 94, B: 162

Hex: c9ab48
R: 201, G: 171, B: 72

Hex: 04c585
R: 4, G: 197, B: 133

Hex: 00bde3
R: 0, G: 189, B: 227

Hex: 168092
R: 22, G: 128, B: 146

Hex: 4c3d69
R: 76, G: 61, B: 105

Hex: 162e51
R: 22, G: 46, B: 81

Color	Token	Family	Grade	Variant	Hex
	'blue-60v'	'blue-vivid'	60	'vivid'	#005ea2
	'yellow-30'	'yellow'	30	—	#c9ab48



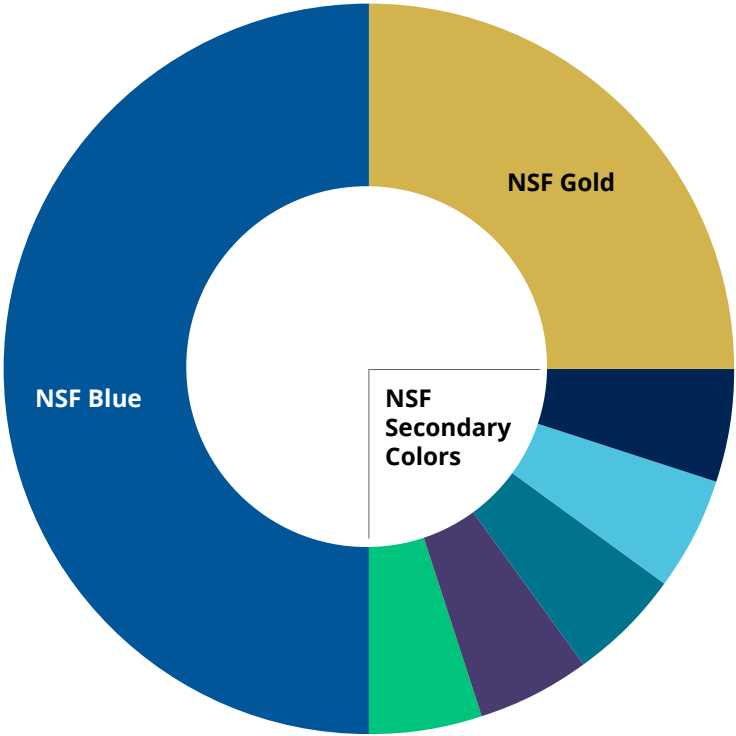
Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Color Palette Usage

Hierarchy and proportions

The NSF color palette must be used consistently. An approximate, proportional breakdown of the intended color usage is shown on the right.

Color can be used in a variety of ways to indicate importance and direct attention to particular elements and information, particularly when it contrasts with its surroundings.



DO
Use colors from the NSF palette.

DO
Use color tints from the NSF palette.

DO
Make sure there is sufficient contrast between the foreground and background.

DON'T
Deviate from the specified proportions.

DON'T
Use less than 10% tints on a light background.

DON'T
Mix colors close to the same values.



Brand Identity Elements & Application

NSF Color Palette Usage

Text and background contrast

It is important to ensure you have sufficient color contrast between the text and background to satisfy the WCAG 2.1 Level AAA accessibility requirements. The examples below show accessible and inaccessible color combinations. Use the [WebAIM Color Contrast Checker](#), or [TPGi Color Contrast Checker](#) to ensure your design meets these requirements.

DO 

Make sure there is sufficient contrast between the text and background.



For optimal visibility and to achieve Section 508 compliance, regular text must be at least 18 point font. Bold text must be at least 14 point.



DON'T 

Don't mix colors close to the same values, as they will blend into one another, resulting in insufficient contrast.



RESOURCES FOR NSF STAFF

Agency Brand Application Requirements

NSF Brand Identity Portal

Iconography

Canva Templates

Design Inspiration

Media Hub

Photography

Illustrations

Virtual Backgrounds



Resources for NSF Staff

Agency Brand Application Requirements

The NSF logo is the sole visual identifier of NSF and must be present on all internal and external agency communications, materials and property. Other elements of the NSF brand identity must also be implemented into internal and external communications.

Communication items that must be properly marked with the NSF logo and visual elements include, but are not limited to:

- 1) Printed and electronic documents intended for distribution.
- 2) Letterheads.
 - a. The NSF Brand Management team has created letterheads for each directorate and office using their logo lockup and are available to create additional letterheads for divisions and programs upon request.
- 3) Reports.
- 4) Graphics.
- 5) Presentations.
- 6) Videos.
- 7) Virtual backgrounds.
 - a. If utilizing NSF image assets or designs.
- 8) Websites.
 - a. In instances when NSF-operated programs maintain their own websites, the website brand application must feature the NSF logo as the primary brand identity and acknowledge the agency association prominently, adhering to requirements in this manual.
- 9) Social media.
 - a. Per the NSF social media policy, NSF directorates and offices are not permitted to run their own social media accounts. Instead, they can submit content to NSF OLPA for consideration and must be sure to include proper brand application on any graphic submissions.
 - b. The NSF National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics, which operates independently, is also required to include NSF markings on their social media channels and accounts.

Correct brand application on a fact sheet.



Correct brand application on a social media graphic.



Resources for NSF Staff

Agency Brand Application Requirements

Communication items that must be properly marked with the NSF logo and visual elements include, but are not limited to (continued):

- 10) Newsletters.
 - a. Any newsletter communications from NSF directorates, offices or programs must include the NSF brand identity.
 - b. The NSF logo should be included in the header of the first page and footers of subsequent pages.
- 11) Email signatures.
 - a. *If* a signature is included in official correspondence from an NSF email address, it should include the NSF logo, either on its own or as part of an official logo lockup.
 - b. An optional and customizable [email signature template](#) is available in the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#).
- 12) Physical property and products such as equipment, instrumentations, vehicles and more.
- 13) All tradeshow and conference materials produced and/or distributed by NSF, recognition awards and agency-issued outreach items.

Correct brand application on agency materials and products.



Correct brand application on promotional materials.



Resources for NSF Staff

Agency Brand Application Requirements

Use of other logos

Outside organizations' logos must not be placed on agency publications except when communicating about a partnership, co-sponsorship or NSF-funded research and activities.

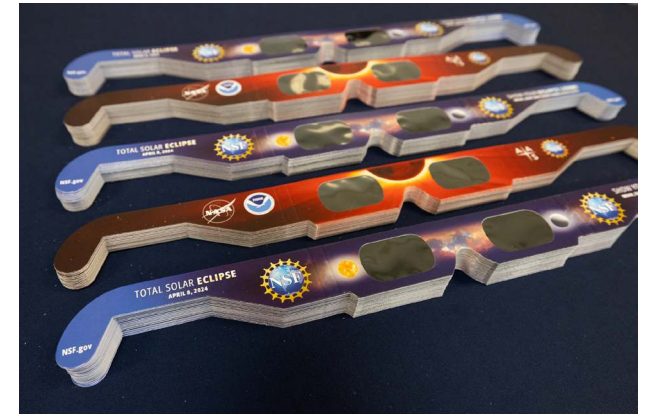
Brand subject matter experts are available as needed to review brand application strategies, review vendor mockups and consult on requests for exceptions and waivers to marking requirements.

NSF encourages consultation with NSF OLPA at the beginning of the design process and can be reached by emailing NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

Use of other organizations' logos must not:

- 1) Result in endorsement of the organization or products or services of the organization;
- 2) Promote NSF in a misleading manner;
- 3) Be used without authorization from the outside organization, or;
- 4) Be inconsistent with the terms of any applicable Memorandum of Understanding (MOU).

Proper cobranding with NSF on equally funded activities.



Proper cobranding on equally funded activities.



Resources for NSF Staff

Agency Brand Application Requirements

Brand clearance for NSF staff

For general communication materials created by NSF staff, NSF OLPA review is welcomed upon request but not necessary.

Approvals must be obtained when working directly with external contractors and vendors for the publication, production, and/or procurement of materials with the NSF brand. This includes webpage design; educational materials; physical outreach products; exhibit, conference and event displays; signage and equipment markings; awards and agency-issued promotional items.

NSF Brand Management will review vendor mockups and provide additional resources for vendors and contractors as appropriate. If the NSF OIRM/DAS or NSF OLPA design teams are developing the materials, there is no need for additional review from NSF OLPA, as they can ensure the designs meet NSF brand standards and vendors are reproducing the NSF brand identity accurately.



NSF Brand Management has released a [request form](#) for NSF staff to submit requests for new lockups, brand clearance review and more.

Appropriate brand clearance must be obtained as follows:

- 1) A specific description of what is being submitted for approval.
- 2) Who was involved in the design process.
- 3) Who in the approval chain has signed off on production and/or procurement.
- 4) For physical markings: A product description, including the size and location of the marking. *(When available, the request must be accompanied by a draft document, preferably from the vendor, that clearly demonstrates where the agency logo will be placed and how it will be reproduced. This draft shall be representative of the final product.)*
- 5) For digital markings: A final draft of the digital file.

A sample of outreach products/vendor mockups that should be provided to NSF Brand Management for brand clearance review.



Agency Brand Application Requirements

Personal use of the NSF logo by agency staff

Use of the NSF logo by staff on personal, nongovernment materials is allowed, provided that the most up-to-date NSF logo is used and minimum size and clear space requirements outlined in this manual are followed. Always check with NSF OGC ethics officials for any conflict-of-interest concerns prior to use.

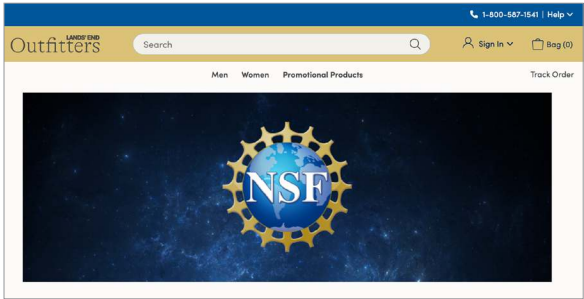
► **Ordering materials with the NSF brand for personal use**

NSF staff are permitted to order materials with their own personal funding, but any vendor proofs should be submitted to NSF Brand Management to ensure brand standard alignment and accuracy of NSF logo reproduction. Some items are available, such as embroidered items, on the [NSF Lands' End storefront](#) and do not require additional review.

NSF staff use of the NSF logo on social media

Use of the NSF logo on personal social media accounts to acknowledge NSF employment is allowed. Please ensure that the most up-to-date NSF logo is used and to abide by clear space requirements as defined in this manual; NSF logo files can be found on the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#). NSF staff are welcome to follow the official NSF social media accounts and share content with personal networks. By sharing publicly accessible content, staff help ensure that no non-public information is inadvertently disclosed, maintaining the integrity and trust of NSF communications.

NSF Lands' End storefront.



NSF Logo embroidery options through the Lands' End storefront on a polo.



Agency Brand Application Requirements

Directorate, office, division and program logos

NSF directorates, offices, divisions and programs, including fellowship and scholarship programs, campaigns and events must present as one voice and one identity of NSF. ***Separate brand identities, including logos, are not permitted.*** The NSF logo is the only logo to be used to identify directorates and programs in NSF. There may be instances where separate logos were allowed for certain programs in the past, and those logos may be “grandfathered” and provided an exception on a case-by-case basis. Please refer to the ***Requests for new or continued use of other brand identities*** section for more information.

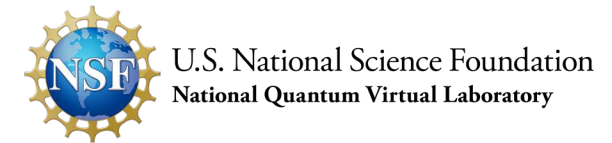
NSF has standardized the design of logo lockups, and requests for new lockups must be submitted to NSF OLPA by emailing NSFbranding@nsf.gov, communications specialists or the NSF DAS Design Team.

At this time, NSF Brand Management develops and supplies all official agency logo + text lockup designs.

Directorate logo lockup example.



NSF program logo lockup example.



Agency Brand Application Requirements

Internal NSF naming conventions

When a directorate, office, division, campaign, event or program name is written, in a logo lockup or otherwise, it must be referenced as “U.S. National Science Foundation [name]” or “NSF [name].” On first reference, the full agency name should be written out as “U.S. National Science Foundation” in the text portion of the lockup in a minimum of the first two instances, followed by “NSF” on subsequent mentions.

Note: “U.S.” should not be included when using the “NSF” acronym and whether to include periods in “U.S.” may be based upon the style preferences of the communicator/publisher.

Use of logo lockups with the NSF logo satisfies logo use requirements.

Naming conventions for recipients

NSF programs, fellowships, events and initiatives must include “NSF” or “U.S. National Science Foundation” in front of their name when referenced in at least the first two mentions.

On first reference, the agency name should be spelled out “U.S. National Science Foundation” when space allows.

- ▶ This may be as part of a larger naming convention or in a mention of the agency on its own, whichever comes first.
- ▶ References to the agency can be written as “NSF” on any subsequent mentions—i.e., “NSF [program/entity name]” or “NSF [program/entity Acronym]”.

! *Note that the apostrophe + s has been removed from naming conventions to minimize confusion on when it is appropriate to use. For example, “NSF Engineering Research Centers” is correct, while “NSF’s Engineering Research Centers” is incorrect.*

NSF News post showcasing correct internal naming conventions.



Naming conventions for an external initiative listed in an area with limited spacing and an area with space for the full NSF acknowledgment.



Agency Brand Application Requirements

Special initiative announcement and campaign design treatments

Thematic design treatments for campaigns and events are encouraged and must always incorporate NSF brand elements, including logo, typography and colors. Creation of a logo from thematic designs or their design elements for ongoing/continuous use is not permitted. When icons are used in designs, NSF custom iconography should be utilized at all times.

For design examples of appropriate treatments, see the [Design Inspiration](#) section. Please submit an [NSF Brand Management Request form](#) with any additional questions on approval or clearance guidance at NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

Identifiable brands for certain communication products

Some official agency initiatives and communication products may develop an identifiable brand as appropriate—requests for permission must be submitted before any development has begun and will be approved on a case-by-case basis. Brand development of these products must be coordinated with NSF OLPA, incorporate the NSF brand elements and be used in combination with the NSF logo.



Requests for new logo development should be submitted before any design work has begun.

Requests for new or continued use of other brand identities

The following items must be included in requests to NSF OLPA and submitted to NSFbranding@nsf.gov:

- 1) Background information on what the visual identity will represent.
- 2) A copy of the existing logo or description of the proposed logo.
- 3) A justification describing the need to produce or continue use of the logo/visual identity and the plans for intended use(s).
- 4) A specific description of the agency interest(s) that will be satisfied, supported or fulfilled through the use of the identifiable brand.
- 5) Request for continued use of logos for communication products already in existence should also include potential impact of discontinued use.
- 6) Name of leadership advocating for the development or continued use of the product logo.

Thematic design treatment example.



Brand identity for communication product.



Agency Brand Application Requirements

Waiver process for NSF staff

Under unique circumstances, waivers to marking requirements and naming conventions may be granted. NSF OLPA may grant an exception to marking requirements and naming conventions, if marking of specific communication materials or products would:

- 1) Compromise the intrinsic independence or neutrality of a program or materials where independence or neutrality is an inherent aspect of the program or materials.
- 2) Incur inordinate costs or be impractical, such as items that are too small or otherwise unsuited for individual marking.
- 3) Be perceived as an endorsement.
- 4) Be inappropriate based on the nature of a partnership.

Waivers should be rare, specific, time-limited and regularly reviewed and never mistaken for blanket approval. Waivers based on historical practices will not be automatically approved.

To begin discussions regarding a potential waiver, requests may be submitted through the internal NSF Brand Management Request Form with the following information:

- 1) NSF program or entity name.
- 2) Program or entity webpage.
- 3) Which specific brand application/acknowledgment requirement(s) the waiver request will address.
- 4) A summary of the concerns/challenges with aligning with the brand application standards.
- 5) Names of leadership that have discussed and are supportive of these concerns and/or those who should be included in conversations regarding this matter.
- 6) Upcoming major outreach events and production timelines, if applicable.

NSF Brand Management Request Form, waiver request.

The screenshot shows the 'NSF Brand Management Request Form' with a blue header. Below the header, there is a section titled 'Brand requirement waiver request' with a blue icon. The text explains that under unique circumstances, waivers to marking requirements and naming conventions may be granted. It lists four examples of such circumstances: 1. Compromise the intrinsic independence or neutrality of a program or materials where independence or neutrality is an inherent aspect of the program or materials. 2. Incur inordinate costs or be impractical, such as items that are too small or otherwise unsuited for individual marking. 3. Be perceived as an endorsement. 4. Be inappropriate based on the nature of a partnership. Below this, there is a question: '4. To begin a waiver request, please first identify which your waiver request pertains to:'. There are two radio button options: 'NSF communications waiver request' (which is selected) and 'Award recipient brand application waiver request'. At the bottom, there are 'Back' and 'Next' buttons.



Resources for NSF Staff

Agency Brand Application Requirements

Ambassadors of NSF

NSF staff are empowered to act as brand ambassadors by sharing the agency's policies and standards with internal and external communities and being a model for cohesive brand application. They have a front-row seat to see the impactful communications produced by NSF and its partners and award recipients. If staff identify potential misuse associated with brand application or lack of the NSF brand identity, they are encouraged to contact the colleague, award recipient, contractor or partner to constructively remind them of NSF's brand standards and guidelines outlined in the policy and this manual, and to point them to the resources available to them. Ongoing and repeat concerns about NSF identity usage can be submitted to NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

Brand support and guidance

Communications specialists are a vital resource and point of contact for award recipients, contractors and partners, as well as for directorates and offices along with the NSF Division of Administrative Services (NSF OIRM/NSF DAS) design team, for questions related to brand application. These communication and design professionals will have additional training opportunities and be well-versed in NSF brand standards, and they will refer requests to NSF Brand Management as appropriate.

Brand subject matter experts in NSF OLPA are available to both internal and external communities to contact directly to request resources, review brand application strategies, consult on requests for exceptions to marking requirements and review brand clearance requests. If there are brand application questions or concerns, NSF OLPA encourages consultation with NSF Brand Management at the beginning of the design process by emailing NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

NSF staff acting as brand ambassadors at eclipse events.



Resources for NSF Staff

NSF Brand Identity Portal

The [***NSF Brand Identity Portal***](#) is a comprehensive collection of brand assets for both NSF staff and external users. The portal is hosted on the [***NSF Media Hub***](#) and contains logo files, fact sheets, policy resources, templates, etc. If any other logo files are needed for specific production requirements, reach out to [***NSFbranding@nsf.gov***](mailto:NSFbranding@nsf.gov) with background information and specifics of the request.

Guides and fact sheets

The Brand Policy Fact Sheet, Quick Start Guides and FAQ Sheets are available on the [***NSF Brand Identity Portal***](#). These resources support understanding of the policy and how to appropriately apply NSF brand elements in communications materials. Separate informational materials are available for both internal and external users.

Letterhead templates

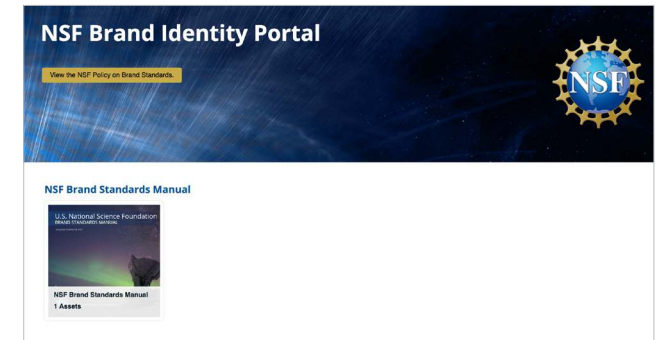
Custom Microsoft Word letterhead templates are available for NSF staff and can be downloaded from the [***NSF Brand Identity Portal***](#). Options are available with both the official NSF logo as well as specific directorate and office logo lockups. ***Please do not alter these templates.***

PowerPoint templates

NSF has custom PowerPoint templates intended for internal users, which are downloadable from the [***NSF Brand Identity Portal***](#). These templates offer many design and content options for NSF staff to create professionally designed presentations. Instructions and resources on how to use the templates and achieve Section 508 compliance are included.

When using official NSF templates, use care to maintain consistency with the template design. NSF OLPA also has a best practice guide for presentations, which is available in the [***NSF Brand Identity Portal***](#).

NSF Brand Identity Portal.



PowerPoint template on NSF Brand Identity Portal.



Resources for NSF Staff

Iconography

Please only use NSF's custom brand iconography in NSF communications. Exceptions to this policy include the use of small contact/connect icons. Contact NSFbranding@nsf.gov to request additional icons to meet your communication needs.

NSF's icons are available for use in communications across the agency. NSF brand iconography must be used to help reinforce key messages and strengthen the NSF visual brand and identity.

The icons are not intended to strictly represent a particular subject or idea. For example, a microscope icon can be used as a visual for communicating concepts in biology, but also for broader concepts such as "discovery" or "focus."

Design principles

The colors, line weights and key elements of the NSF icons work together to create subliminal brand application that strengthens the agency's distinct style. NSF's new icons make use of several stylings for design flexibility, which are depicted to the right.

Icon library

The icon library is available to NSF staff through the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#). New icons are added regularly.

Color on blue icon.



All white on transparent icon.



Color on transparent icon.



Resources for NSF Staff

Iconography

Icon Guidelines

Follow these guidelines to ensure icons are legible to viewers:

- **Clear space**
An icon must be surrounded by clear space. The amount of white space on each side of the icon must be at least 1/8 of the icon’s width or height.
- **Background**
When printed, icons must be no smaller than 1/2" x 1/2" or 48 pixels.

Correct contact icons.



contact icons: **correct**

Correct contact icons, one color.



contact icons: **correct**

Clear space.



Icon clear space guidance.

Icon width/height	0.5" or 48 px	1" or 96 px	1.5" or 144px	2" or 192px	3" or 288px
Clear space on each side	1/16" or 6px	1/8" or 12px	3/16" or 18px	1/4" or 24px	3/8" or 36px



Resources for NSF Staff

Iconography

Icon Guidelines (continued)

Follow these guidelines to ensure icons are legible to viewers:

► Scale

Icons must not be distorted. They must always be scaled proportionally.

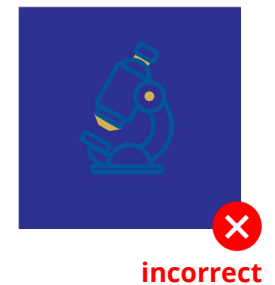
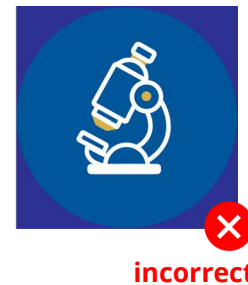
► Background

Icons must be Section 508 compliant when placed against a background. To ensure your icon has a compliant level of contrast against its background, use the [WebAIM Color Contrast Checker](#) or another web-based tool. Icons must not be placed on a similar background color. For example, do not use an all-white icon on a light gray background or an icon in a blue circle on a similarly shaded blue background.

Icon scaling examples.



Icon contrast examples.



Resources for NSF Staff

Iconography

Usage instructions and examples

Icons can be used in a multitude of ways—in infographics, as a large bullet point, or as focal elements for example.

Icons should be used to enhance information and reinforce concepts. They should neither be used as the sole conveyor of information nor need explanatory text. A few examples for each icon variation can be found to the right.

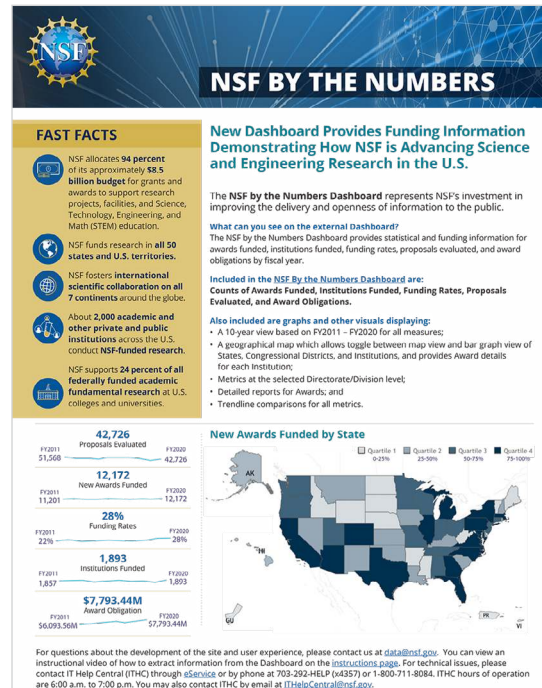
File types

Icons can be used in both print and digital formats. These formats may require the use of different icon file types. The icon library includes both SVG and PNG file types ready for use.

Note that PNG files must be used at a minimum of 72ppi for digital formats and 300dpi for print.

Contact NSFbranding@nsf.gov if you have any additional questions.

Color on blue, infographics.



2022-2024 Strategic Plan, white icons example.



white on transparent, hero image.



Resources for NSF Staff

Canva Templates

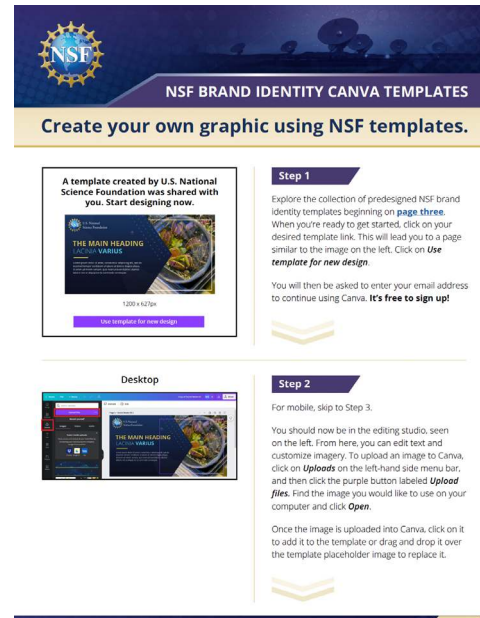
Canva template use

NSF created custom Canva templates available for staff. Users have options for a multitude of uses, such as posters, postcards and more. The templates can be accessed through the instructional document is also available on the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#) which explains creation, adjustments and export settings in Canva.

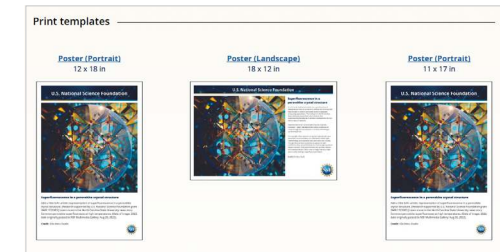
These templates are meant to inspire and alterations within brand guidelines are acceptable.

Contact NSFbranding@nsf.gov with any questions.

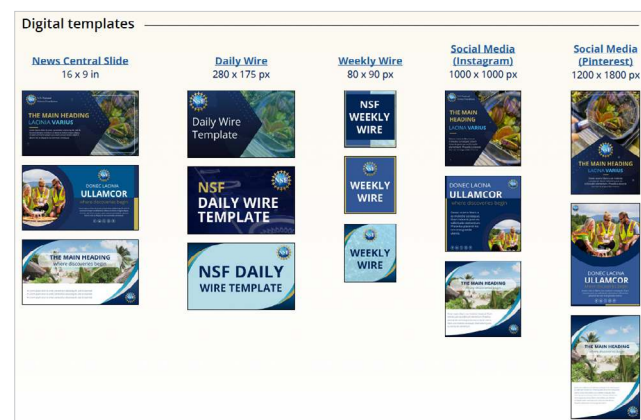
Canva template instructions.



Canva print templates.



Canva digital templates.



Resources for NSF Staff

Design Inspiration

Design inspiration

Creating unique and engaging communications materials using the fundamental principles of NSF's brand identity is highly encouraged. The following examples highlight ways in which NSF's color palette, typography, iconography and photography are combined to elevate the agency's message while maintaining visual consistency.

More design inspiration can be found in the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#).

Discovery Files WW.



Evergreen NSF banner.



Animal Madness banner.



EDU Directorate.



Director's Awards promo.



Citizen Science Month social graphic.



NSF banner.



NSF fact sheet.



DAS RMT.



Resources for NSF Staff

Design Inspiration

Special initiative and communication design treatments

Thematic design for campaigns and events is encouraged and must always incorporate the NSF brand identity, which includes logo, typography, iconography and colors.

These design treatments enable the creation of unique, diverse and engaging communications while creating a cohesive look and feel across materials and maintaining and strengthening the NSF brand identity.

Thematic design treatments are not intended to stand on its own as a logo. Treatments do not have transparent backgrounds and are not intended to be placed on top of other backgrounds and graphics.

NSF 75th Anniversary Campaign

NSF 75th Anniversary Portal banner.



NSF 75th Anniversary PowerPoint template.



NSF 75th Anniversary Portal graphics.



Science Happens Here Campaign

SHH banner.



SHH screen.



SHH poster.



Resources for NSF Staff

NSF Media Hub

NSF Media Hub

The [NSF Media Hub](#) is NSF's digital asset management system, a vast and ever-growing collection of a variety of media asset types. It is intended to be a collaborative space for hosting images, illustrations, graphics and brand assets which can be shared across NSF and/or made available to external users.

Content utilization

Design teams and communicators across NSF use content uploaded by staff, facilities, centers and NSF recipients to develop communication materials which spotlight impactful research and the important work being done across NSF. Fantastic images related to NSF-invested activities are also highlighted by NSF social media channels. Images must be credited appropriately based on the information provided with each asset, and the *credit must travel with the image if it is syndicated or otherwise picked up by other parties*. Images owned by NSF should be credited with "U.S. National Science Foundation/[artist's name]" as appropriate.

Portals

Portals are a great way to share and organize images. They provide a secure way to share NSF assets with external users and can be password-protected to distribute embargoed or private assets securely. Portals can track viewer activity and locations to provide powerful metrics and insights.

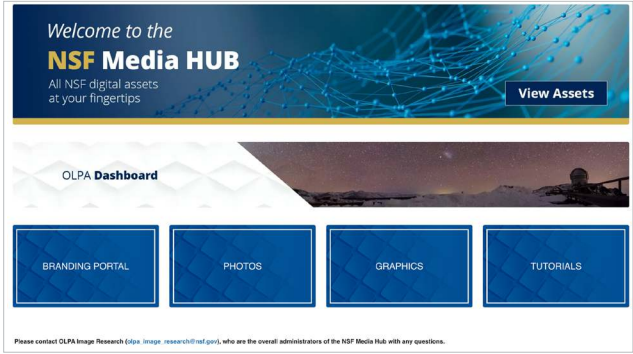
Uploading images to the NSF Media Hub

NSF highly encourages uploading imagery to the NSF Media Hub, and Single Sign-On (SSO) is supported for ease of access. Users will be asked to add metadata to make the upload process seamless.

The requested fields are: Caption, Credit, Title (if applicable), a field to denote who the assets are for in NSF and a checkbox that gives NSF permission to use the assets. The [NSF OLPA multimedia research](#) team will be notified of the new assets via email and will let users know that they are available in the NSF Media Hub admin dashboard. Please email olpa_image_research@nsf.gov with questions or support needs.

You can now request award recipients and other partners to upload image assets directly to the NSF Media Hub. See the [Media Hub](#) section for further instructions.

NSF Media Hub.



NSF Media Hub Portal example.



Photography

NSF photography components

NSF uses imagery to aid communications and visual storytelling. Use of original organizational photography and that of recipient work and projects add authenticity and impact. Imagery directly related to NSF-supported activity should always be prioritized over stock photography.

Image rights and ethics in captioning

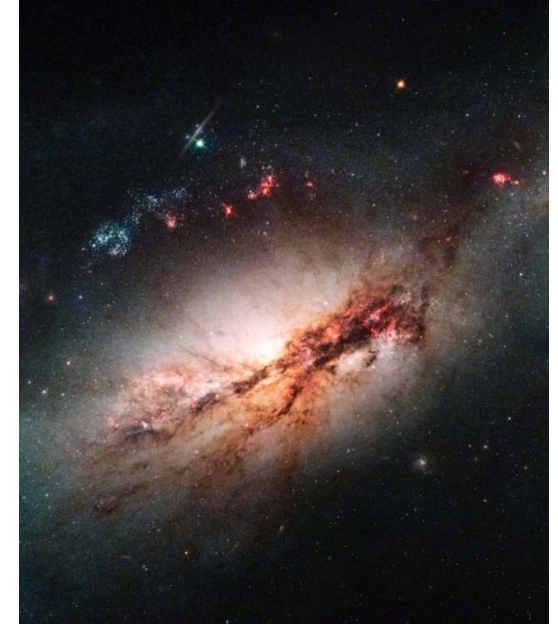
Image attribution must always be visibly notated when using NSF and/or other institutions' photography. Images owned by NSF should be credited with "U.S. National Science Foundation/ [artist's name]" as appropriate.

In addition to image credits, captions should also be included where feasible (e.g., fact sheets, social media posts, etc.). Captions must be accurate and display information in a clear and concise manner. Original captions from the asset's metadata should be utilized when possible.

Since captions directly impact how a reader perceives an image, the context must match appropriately and truthfully ***It is never ethical to change captioning for an image to fit content.***

The [Multimedia Guide](#) is available on [InsideNSF](#) (NSF staff only) and explains permissions, the [1515 Form](#) and other multimedia requirements.

! *Image usage rights should always be visibly notated when using NSF and/or other institutions' photography.*



Resources for NSF Staff

Illustrations

The use of illustrations and illustrated elements serve to communicate the specific and continual contributions of the agency to science and society. NSF illustrations cover a wide variety of topics and themes targeted for specific audiences that convey complex science concepts in a visual way that supports the agency's mission.

The use of illustrations is meant to support a written narrative to make complex ideas more clear and aesthetically pleasing, to represent the NSF brand and to help tell stories thoughtfully. Use of the NSF color palette within illustrations allows for reinforcement of brand identity as well as seamless coordination within the graphic design of products.

When possible, illustrations should aim to be evergreen and capable of being reused in multiple contexts. Building in flexibility is an important part of planning illustrations that can represent a range of related topics and can be pulled apart and repurposed separately as a stand-alone product or added to additional illustrations.

NSF OLPA has science illustrators and animators on staff. Reach out to OLPAdigitalengage@nsf.gov to inquire about project collaboration.

Illustrations that showcase coordinating colors outside of the NSF palette (e.g., reds/oranges/brown tones not included in the expanded palette). The NSF color palette must still be dominant.

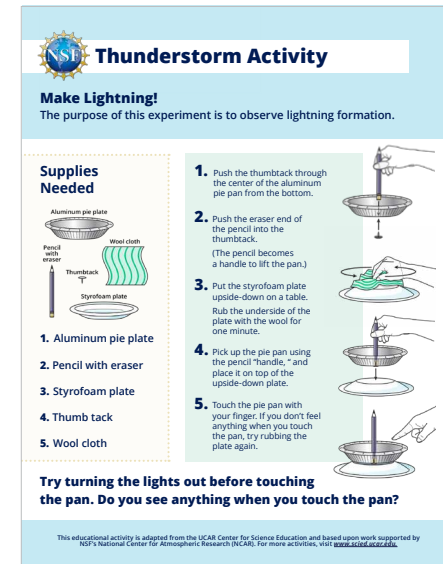
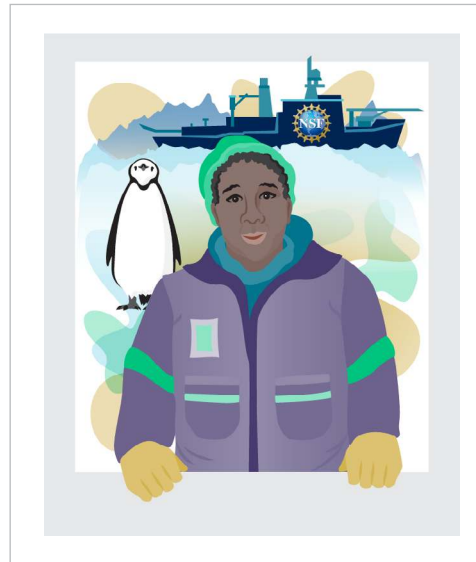
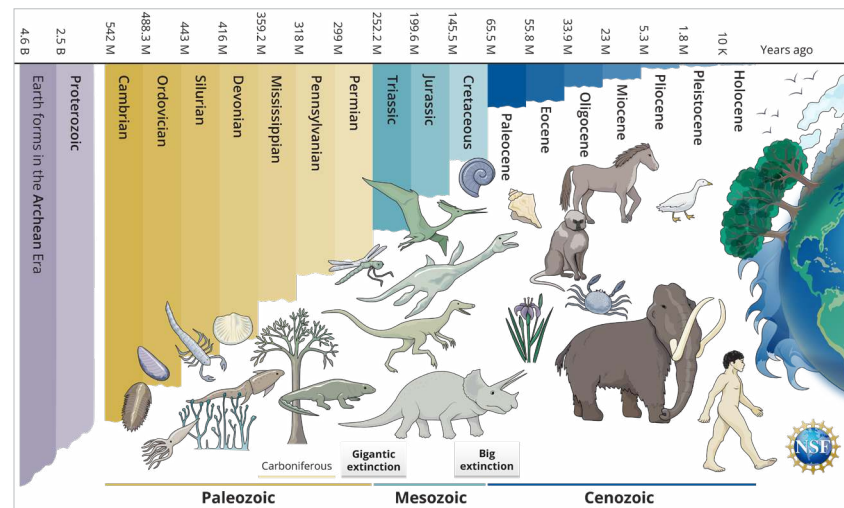


Illustration created entirely with the primary and expanded color palettes.



Resources for NSF Staff

Virtual Backgrounds

Virtual backgrounds for NSF staff

NSF creates virtual backgrounds for NSF staff that celebrate NSF-related imagery, which are hosted on nsf.gov/virtual-backgrounds.

Special-use backgrounds are developed to commemorate holidays, remembrance/honor days and other special occasions.

If creating your own virtual background, make sure the correct logo is included. Templates are also available on the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#). If you have an idea for a virtual background, email olpa_image_research@nsf.gov.

NSF-created virtual background.



Special-use NSF-designed virtual background.



RESOURCES FOR EXTERNAL USERS

Award Recipient Brand Application Requirements

Logo Position and Prominence

Brand Clearance

Waiver Process

Logo Usage by Partners & Others

Website

Video

Awardee Collaboration/Network

Logo Application Examples

NSF Brand Identity Portal

Logo Lockup Template and Instructions

Messaging Requirements

Social Media Requirements

Media Hub

Media Outreach & Press Releases

Media Interviews

Press Clippings

Media Advisories

News Releases

Award Recipient Announcements



Award Recipient Brand Application Requirements

As the [***NSF Policy on Brand Standards***](#) guidance becomes incorporated into award terms and conditions, it will become a requirement for award recipients to include the NSF full-color logo—along with the otherwise required funding acknowledgments—in print and digital products related to NSF-invested research and activities.

!

The award recipient must acknowledge NSF support in research papers in accordance with the publication guidelines while following NSF brand standards to the extent feasible. The public summary for public consumption should be written using *plain language standards*.

Example of correct brand application with a partner logo lockup.



Resources for External Users

Logo Position and Prominence

Logo position and prominence

The placement and prominence of the NSF logo by awardees will depend on the funding they receive from NSF.

- **Predominately (more than 50%) NSF-invested activities with an award of \$1 million or more** must pair their visual identity (if one exists) with the NSF logo in all instances and include “NSF” in front of their name in textual references, including when using acronyms, such as “NSF [entity name].”

When a program name is written, in a logo lockup or otherwise, it must include “NSF” or ‘U.S. National Science Foundation’ as part of their official name when referenced in at least the first two mentions on each page.

On first reference, the agency name should be spelled out “U.S. National Science Foundation” when space allows.

This may be as part of a larger naming convention or in a mention of the agency on its own, whichever comes first.

- References to the agency can be written as “NSF” on any subsequent mentions—i.e., “U.S. National Science Foundation [Recipient project/entity name]” or “NSF [Recipient project/entity acronym].”

When an entity logo is paired with the NSF logo, the NSF logo must always be to the left, with the entity logo sized to the height of the globe in the NSF logo. Any new entities must include “NSF” as part of their official name. An optional [logo lockup template](#) is available for ease of implementation. ***All created logo lockups must be submitted to NSF Brand Management for approval prior to implementation.***

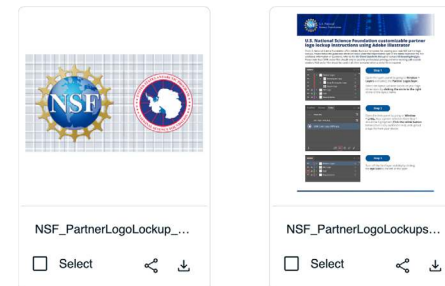
Once developed and approved, the created logo lockup should be placed on all communication materials along with the standard acknowledgment and disclaimer as written in the [NSF PAPPG](#), when spacing allows.

Any identifying marks or logos created by the recipient, program, facility, center or vehicle must play a secondary role in the overall brand identity. ***The facility or program logo must never be the primary identifier of a predominately NSF-invested facility, vehicle, program, center, website or any other form of communication.***

Correct cobranded event brand application.



NSF logo lockup template, instructions for use and correct logo lockup example.



Resources for External Users

Logo Position and Prominence

Logo position and prominence (continued)

- ▶ **When NSF is the majority funding agency**, contributing a greater percentage than other supporters, the NSF logo should appear substantially larger than the other accompanying logos and be placed above the series of accompanying logos.

Note that in a series of logos, it is not necessary to use the “U.S. National Science Foundation” text to accompany the logo. In these cases, it is preferable to have the text elsewhere on the material, where the text will be more impactful.

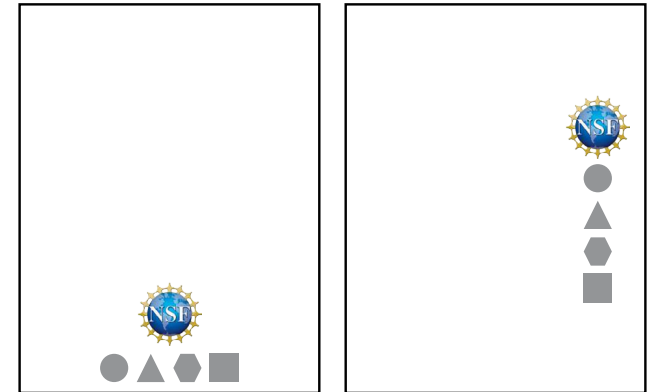


- ▶ **When NSF is a partial investor among other partners**, the NSF logo should always be placed furthest to the left in a horizontal series of logos. In a vertical series, the NSF logo should be placed at the top. As logo shapes vary among sponsors, use the height and width of only the NSF globe as your guide.

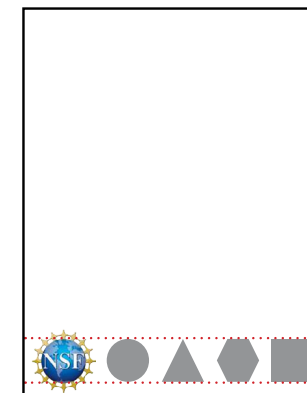
In certain instances, the logo prominence and naming convention requirements may be waived by NSF OLPA in consultation with the program office and others as appropriate, visit the [Waiver Process](#) section for further information.



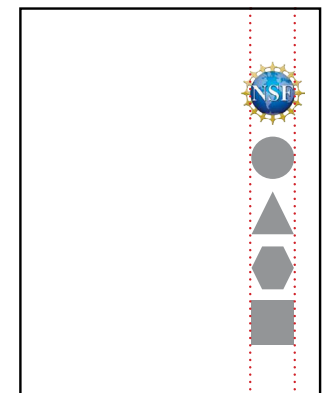
NSF logo prominence when NSF is the majority funding agency.



In a horizontal series of co-sponsors.



In a vertical series of co-sponsors.



Logo Position and Prominence

Logo position and prominence

- ▶ **When NSF is an equal investor in a co-funded agreement** and the NSF logo will be placed among a horizontal series of outside organizational logos, the NSF logo must always be placed furthest to the left of the series. In the case of placement in a vertical series, the NSF logo must be placed at the top of the series.

When the partnerships are equal, all the logos must carry the same visual weight. As logo shapes vary among sponsors, use the height and width of only the NSF globe as your guide. This ensures NSF's visual weight among similarly sized logos.

Note that in a series of logos, it is not necessary to use the "U.S. National Science Foundation" text to accompany the logo. In these cases, it is preferable to have the text elsewhere on the item, where the text will be more impactful. When materials, facilities or vehicles are designed with or by a co-sponsor, the full guidelines for the NSF identity do not apply in their entirety, though it is still essential to use the correct logo and prominent placement.

- ▶ **When NSF is an partial investor in a co-funded agreement**, the NSF logo should always be placed furthest to the left in a horizontal series of logos. In a vertical series, the NSF logo should be placed at the top.

As logo shapes vary among sponsors, use the height and width of only the NSF globe as your guide.

Example of a co-funded interagency agreement



Additional contractor requirements

Contractors with NSF must follow brand application requirements outlined in the [*NSF Policy on Brand Standards*](#) as appropriate and in accordance with their contract terms and conditions.



Brand Clearance

Brand review and clearance requirements for NSF award recipients

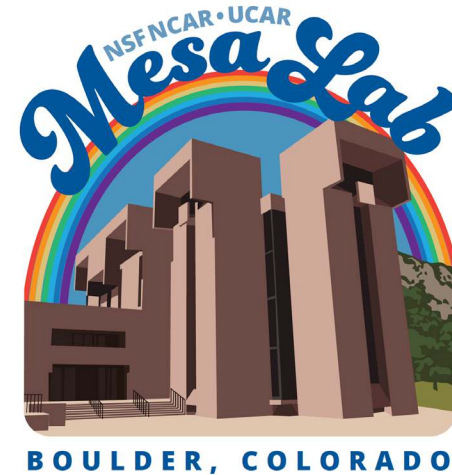
Approvals must be obtained from NSF by contacting NSFbranding@nsf.gov before the publication of logo lockups and webpages or the publication, production, and/or procurement of all vendor produced educational materials; exhibit, tradeshow, conference and event materials and displays; signage on NSF-invested facilities, vehicles, and centers; instrumentation and equipment over \$150,000; videos and documentaries; and physical outreach products and promotional items.

It is extremely important these high-profile and resource-intensive products are produced with accuracy. An NSF Brand Management subject matter expert can address questions from outside vendors to ensure correct logo reproduction by contacting NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

! *Requests for brand clearance and approval may be submitted to NSFbranding@nsf.gov and must include the following information:*

- 1) A specific description of what is being submitted for approval.
- 2) Who was involved in the design process.
- 3) NSF award number, program officer (PO) and any funding level information readily available.
- 4) For physical markings: A product description, including the size and location of the marking. *(When available, the request must be accompanied by a draft document, preferably from the vendor, that clearly demonstrates where the agency logo will be placed and how it will be reproduced. This draft shall be representative of the final product.)*
- 5) For digital markings: A final draft of the digital file.

Correct naming conventions in an area with reduced spacing.



Correct physical marking on a hat developed by Oregon State University featuring NSF R/V Taani.



Waiver Process

Waiver process for award recipients

Under unique circumstances, waivers to marking requirements and naming conventions may be granted. NSF OLPA—in consultation with the communications specialists, program directors or office heads, awarded institution/organization, when necessary, NSF OGC and/or NSF OD—may grant an exception to marking requirements and naming conventions, if marking of specific communication materials or products would:

- 1) Compromise the intrinsic independence or neutrality of a program or materials where independence or neutrality is an inherent aspect of the program or materials.
- 2) Incur inordinate costs or be impractical, such as items that are too small or otherwise unsuited for individual marking.
- 3) Be perceived as an endorsement.
- 4) Be inappropriate based on the nature of a partnership.

Waivers should be rare, specific, time-limited and regularly reviewed and never mistaken for blanket approval. Waivers based on historical practices will not be automatically approved.

To begin discussions regarding a potential waiver, requests may be submitted by the award recipient, the NSF program office or NSF communications specialist by emailing NSFbranding@nsf.gov with the following information:

- 1) Basic award information:
 - a. Award name and number.
 - b. NSF program officer.
 - c. Project webpage (if available).
 - d. Background information regarding NSF funding and other partners or sponsors.
- 2) Which specific brand application/acknowledgment requirement(s) the waiver is being requested for.
- 3) Summary of the concerns/challenges with aligning with those brand application standards.
- 4) Names of officials that have discussed and are supportive of these concerns and/or those who should be included in conversations.

The NSF program office or NSF communications specialist may also submit a waiver request on behalf of a recipient by using the internal [NSF Brand Management Request Form](#).



Resources for External Users

Logo Usage by Partners & Others

Partnerships and others

For logo use not covered as allowable in the [*NSF Policy on Brand Standards*](#), an outside organization must have a relationship with NSF before the organization can obtain permission to use any NSF logos on non-NSF publications, products and/or websites. Examples of proper relationships include co-hosted conferences and seminars, an NSF official speaking at non-NSF events, and engagement in activities that mutually further the missions of NSF and the non-NSF entity. A relationship, particularly with industry, public sector and international partners, may require brand use guidelines in a new or existing MOU.

A request for the outside use of the NSF logo must meet the following criteria:

- 1) Be aligned to the goals of the agency and/or the research it funds.
- 2) **Not** result in endorsement of the organization or products of the organization.
- 3) **Not** be misleading or embarrass the agency.
- 4) **Not** be used without authorization from NSF OLPA.

Requests for logo use by partners and others may be submitted to NSFbranding@nsf.gov and must include the following information:

- 1) A specific description of how the NSF logo will be used, including the materials it will be used on; location of the marking; and the size and proximity of the NSF logo to the seal, logo, emblem or banner of other organizations, agencies, businesses, corporations or other entities.
- 2) Whenever possible, the request should be accompanied by a draft document that clearly demonstrates where the agency logo will be placed and any acknowledgment or disclaimer language that will be included. This draft shall be representative of the final product.
- 3) A description of the agency's relationship, if any, to the requesting party.
- 4) A statement explaining the agency interest(s) that will be satisfied, supported or fulfilled through the requested use of the marking, and why it would not result in a perception of favoritism or endorsement by the agency.

Example of a correct partner logo lockup with Intel.



Example of correct partner brand implementation.



Resources for External Users

Website

Website

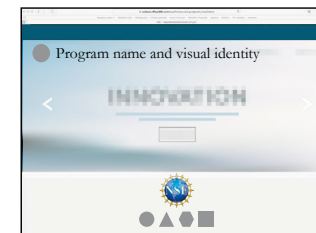
Like other materials, recipient project and entity websites should acknowledge NSF support through logo application in addition to the [NSF PAPPG](#) acknowledgment and disclaimer language.

Refer to the [Logo Position and Prominence](#) section for guidance on application of the NSF brand identity on predominately and partially NSF-invested activity websites. It is acceptable to have the partner logos at the bottom of the program webpage as shown to the right, when NSF is a majority or partial contributor.

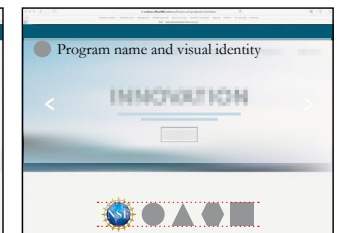
When a project is predominately (more than 50%) NSF-invested with an award of \$1M or more, website brand application must feature the NSF logo in the header/main website visual identity by using the required NSF + recipient logo lockup.

Website brand application and logo lockups must be submitted through NSFbranding@nsf.gov

NSF logo alignment when NSF is the majority investor.



NSF logo alignment when NSF is a partial investor.



Correct NSF-invested center brand application on a website.



Resources for External Users

Video

Video

The same fundamental principles that apply to print and digital materials when using the NSF logo also apply to video products. The NSF logo and a credit line should be included in all products developed under an NSF award. Videos and documentaries in which the research depicted was predominately invested by NSF must include a detailed acknowledgement slide at the end of the video indicating the research was supported by NSF. Videos in which the production was predominately supported by an NSF investment should also follow the brand application guidelines mentioned in this manual.

The acknowledgement design is at the discretion of the video creator but will include the NSF logo with “U.S. National Science Foundation” spelled out. Using a logo “bug” is not necessary for the duration of the video product, but is permissible. The logo may appear in any of the four corners of the screen.

When producing video regarding an entity or research that is co-invested, the guidelines explained in the [Logo Position and Prominence](#) section are applicable. The timing of the logo and acknowledgment in these cases is at the discretion of the video creator.

For video content that was only partially based on NSF-invested research and was not produced as part of the NSF award, an acknowledgment line without the NSF logo is appropriate, such as: *“This work was supported in part by the U.S. National Science Foundation”*.

Any requests to use predominately NSF-invested activities (with awards of \$1 million or more) for commercial photography, documentaries and film production must be submitted to NSF OLPA for review and approval by emailing NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

NSF logo.



NSF logo “bug”.



NSF logo bug on a produced video.



Awardee Collaboration/Network

Awardee collaboration and network guidance

The recommendations in this section pertain to centralized coordination efforts and collaborations of award recipients from an NSF program aimed at distinguishing these groups from the NSF program itself.

If a centralized coordination effort of awardees created a visual identity, it should be paired with the NSF logo as the primary identifier.

- ***The NSF logo must be placed to the left with a vertical line separating the NSF logo from the collaboration logo.*** A logo lockup template is available in the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#) for convenience. ***To clarify how the site is managed, any text in a collaboration logo should include a descriptor such as “collaboration,” “network” or “hub” and not use the word “program.”*** Collaborations may use official NSF program logo lockups only when paired with a collaboration logo or additional text, not as a sole identifier.

If a collaboration does not have a logo, they may use text instead. The NSF logo should be placed first, followed by a vertical line and then the [Collaboration Name] text. The text may include the program name but should ideally be followed by “collaboration,” “network” or a similar descriptor so as to not be confused with the program itself. A template is available on the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#) as a resource for users to pair these three elements together.

- ***A collaboration logo must not be used as the primary visual identity or used in place of the NSF logo by individual centers/institutes/etc. It must also not be used by the NSF program as the program’s brand identity.***

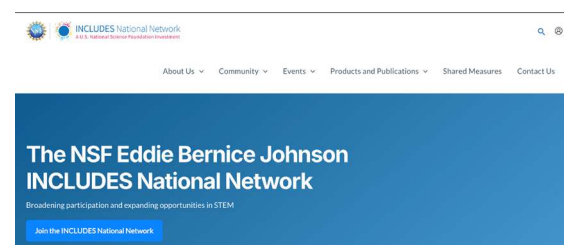
If a predominately NSF-invested entity would also like to use the collaboration brand identity, then they should use the NSF/collaboration logo lockup once reviewed and approved by NSF Brand Management. If used as part of the primary brand identity for the site it should then be followed by the individual entity logo, or name if no logo exists. These tri-logo lockup designs should also be submitted for review.

Collaboration websites should include acknowledgment text and the standard disclaimer as written in the [NSF PAPPG](#) ***ideally at the top of the homepage in an effort to clarify how the site is managed.*** Other communication materials produced by a collaboration should also share this information prominently.

Example of correct collaboration logo lockup.



Example of correct collaboration brand implementation.



Resources for External Users

Logo Application Examples

Property and equipment signage

NSF-invested activities

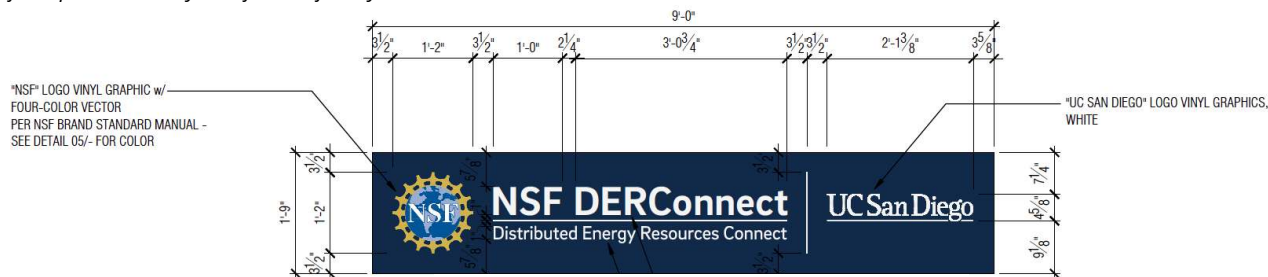
NSF-invested activities are the cornerstones of the U.S. scientific and research enterprise. As such, it is essential that the agency identifiers be applied in such a way that they show NSF's funding and support of the facilities, centers, and instrumentation and equipment over \$150,000. Either through signage or direct application to the facility, instrument or equipment, NSF identifiers must be prominently displayed.

Application of the NSF logo applies to existing and new equipment, facilities and buildings. Research infrastructure, including major facilities and mid-scale RI, predominately NSF-funded and owned by NSF must include "U.S. National Science Foundation" in text on signage in addition to the logo.

Vendor mockups for all signage must be submitted to NSFbranding@nsf.gov for review and approval. In situations when brand application in alignment with these guidelines may not be appropriate or feasible, please consult with the cognizant program officer and NSF Brand Management.

When it is not possible to have NSF brand identity directly on the exterior of the building, an identifying sign must be erected with NSF's brand identity prominently displayed in a location that is most viewable by the general public. For example, placing the sign at the entrance road to a field site where NSF-invested equipment is located instead of on the equipment itself. The size of the sign must be reasonable and appropriately scaled to match the location selected, as well as properly identify NSF and the operating institution or organization. Signage must always appear clean and well-maintained.

Correct signage brand implementation and NSF naming conventions on a vendor mockup for a predominately NSF-funded facility.



Correct NSF brand implementation on a predominately funded facility door.



Resources for External Users

Logo Application Examples

Property and equipment signage

Predominately funded by NSF

Regarding buildings and field sites, it is ideal to have the NSF identifiers affixed to the building either alone or in tandem with the name of the facility or center. The preferred configuration for use on a building is the text to the right configuration. Refer to the [NSF Logo Text Configuration](#) section for additional details and information. On buildings, the text becomes as important as the logo itself and therefore can be increased in size. The minimum size of the text must equal the size of the letters “NSF” in the logo. The text must not exceed the size of the globe. Overall size must be determined by the size of allowable space on the building. On buildings and permanent signs, the logo and text may be created in a material such as stainless steel and are acceptable in either a brushed or polished finish.

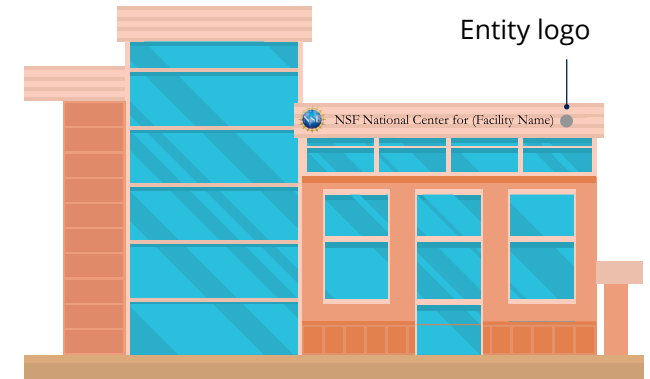
It is essential that the guidelines concerning partnerships and placement among other logos be adhered to at all times, whether on the building itself or on the signage.

If the facility, center, instrumentation or equipment has its own identifying logo associated with the institution or organization, the NSF logo must still be displayed as the primary identifier on any signage or communications and never with less than equal representation.

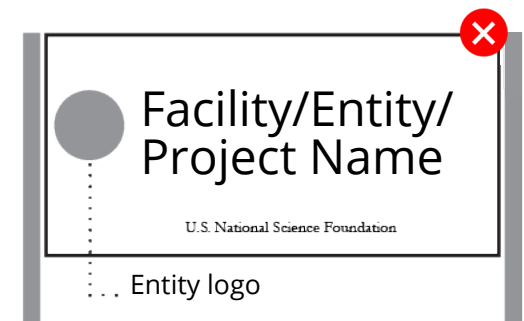
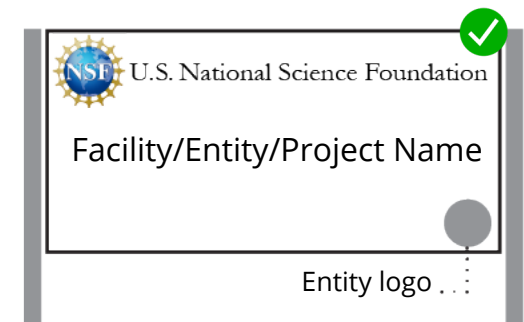
Examples of predominately funded facility signage with correct NSF brand implementation.



Building marking for predominately NSF-invested activities.



Building signage for predominately NSF-invested activities.



Resources for External Users

Logo Application Examples

Property and equipment signage

Partially NSF-invested activities

When a building or field site is not predominately invested by NSF, refer to the guidance regarding partnerships and NSF logo placement described in the [Logo Position and Prominence](#) section. The same rules will apply to building and field site signage. See examples to the right.

Instrumentation and equipment

The goal with brand application on NSF-owned instrumentation and equipment is to ensure the NSF identifiers are placed in areas with the most exposure and the least operational interruption. Agency identifiers must be applied in such a way that they show NSF's funding and support of instrumentation and equipment investments over \$150,000. Paints or adhesives must be weather-resistant or otherwise appropriate for the material and environment in which they are used and replaced when they show signs of deterioration. The size of the logo applied to instrumentation and equipment must be reasonable and appropriately scaled to match the location selected.

On partially NSF-invested buildings.



On partially NSF-invested building signs.



Resources for External Users

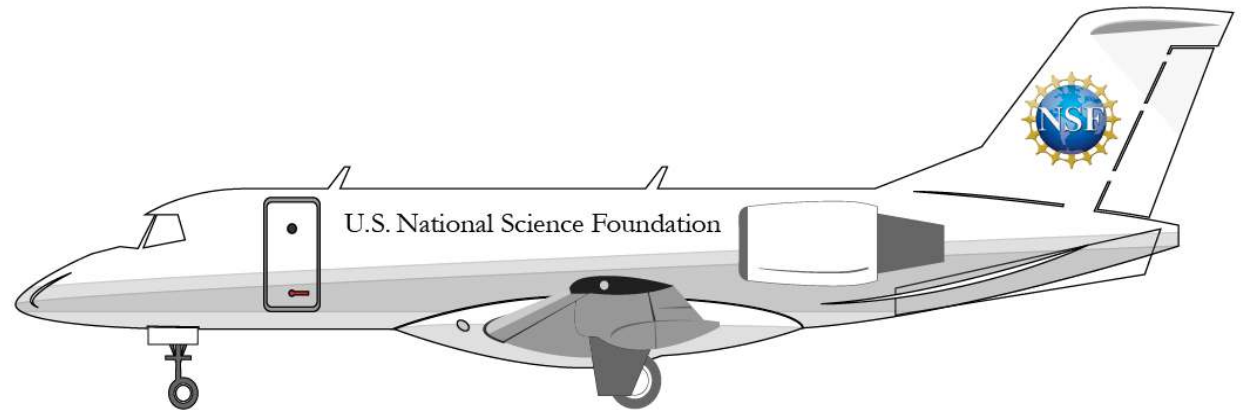
Logo Application Examples

Property and equipment signage

Airplanes

On airplanes, the goal is to place the NSF logo where it is most visible while on the ground. The preferred placement on an airplane is on the vertical stabilizer. The “U.S. National Science Foundation” text must also be prominently placed, preferably along the upper region of the fuselage. Guidelines on the NSF text proximity to the logo do not apply. The program name or cooperating agency identifiers can be substantially smaller and placed on the front section of the plane.

On airplanes.



Example of an airplane with appropriate logo application.



Resources for External Users

Logo Application Examples

Property and equipment signage

Helicopters

On helicopters, like airplanes, the goal is to place the NSF logo where it is most visible while on the ground. The logo must be placed in an area where it is easily seen. The “U.S. National Science Foundation” text must also be prominently placed, preferably along the tail boom. Guidelines on NSF text proximity to the logo do not apply here. The program name or cooperating agency identifiers can be placed substantially smaller, elsewhere on the helicopter.

On helicopters.



Example of a helicopter with appropriate brand application.



Resources for External Users

Logo Application Examples

Property and equipment signage

Vehicles

With regard to vehicles such as trucks, vans and cars, and industrial equipment such as forklifts, tractors and loaders, the NSF identifiers must be placed in areas where they are easily seen and where they are unobstructed by physical features (e.g., mufflers, gas tanks) on the vehicle. Similar to the airplane and helicopter, guidelines on the NSF text proximity to the logo do not apply here.

On vehicles.



Resources for External Users

Logo Application Examples

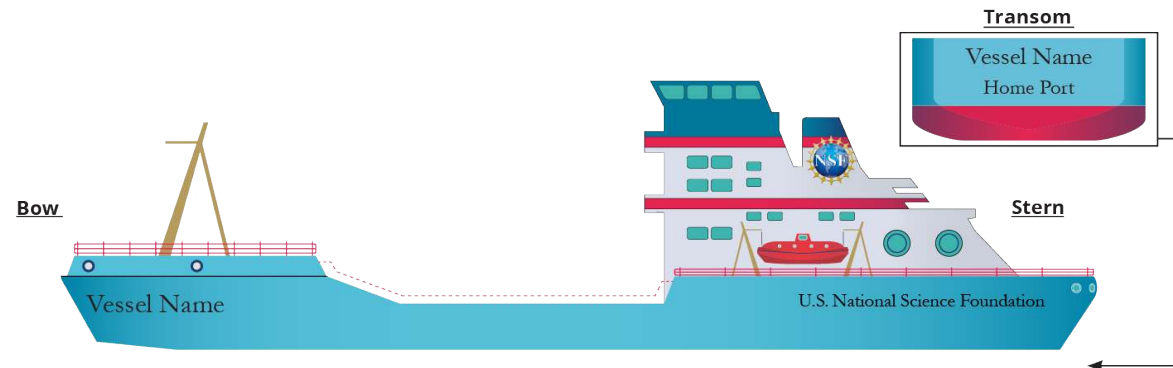
Property and equipment signage

Vessels

On vessels, when physical marking is allowable, the NSF identifiers must be placed in areas where they are easily seen, for example on the stack where they are unobstructed by physical features (e.g., lifeboats and other equipment). The size of the NSF identifiers must be proportionate to the area where they are placed, but easily recognizable from a reasonable distance.

Guidelines on the NSF text proximity to the logo do not apply here.

On vessels.



Example of a research vehicle with appropriate brand application.



Resources for External Users

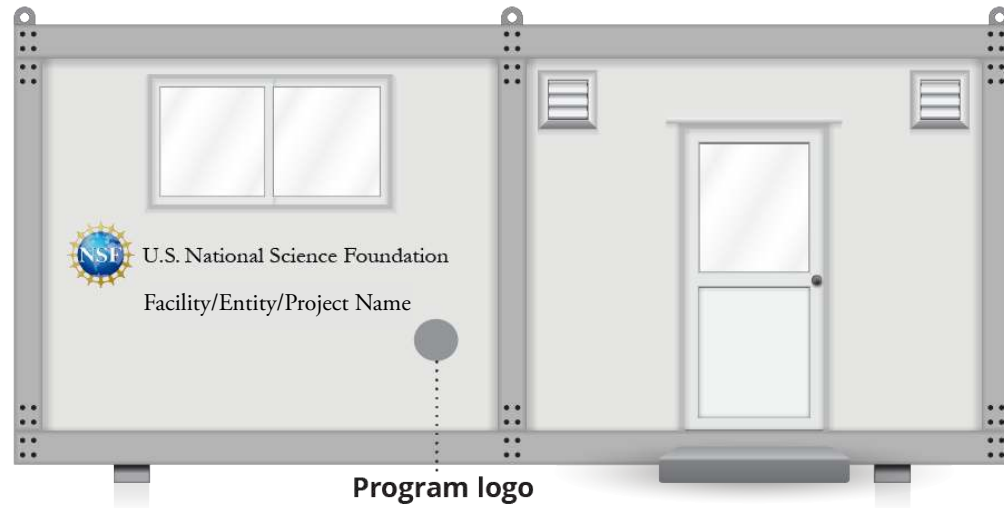
Logo Application Examples

Property and equipment signage

Portable scientific equipment

On portable scientific support equipment such as laboratory units, winches or large instruments, it is ideal to have the NSF identifiers affixed to the outside surface either alone or in tandem with the name of the research program. The preferred configuration is the horizontal logo variation. Overall size must be determined by the size of allowable space on the unit. Guidelines concerning partnerships and placement among other logos must be adhered to at all times.

On portable scientific support equipment.



NSF Brand Identity Portal

NSF Brand Identity Portal

The [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#) includes a comprehensive collection of brand assets for external users. The portal is hosted online for ease of access and contains official NSF logo files, fact sheets, policy resources, etc. If any other logo files are needed for specific production needs, reach out to NSFbranding@nsf.gov with background information and specifics of the request. NSF is continually updating content and providing more resources on the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#).

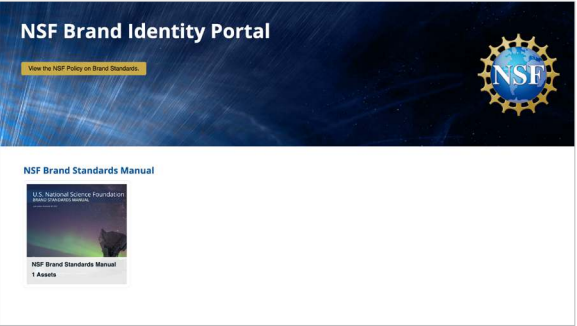
Guides and fact sheets

The portal includes fact sheets, FAQs sheets and more. These guides help users quickly familiarize themselves with elements and standards of the NSF brand identity required for proper brand application.

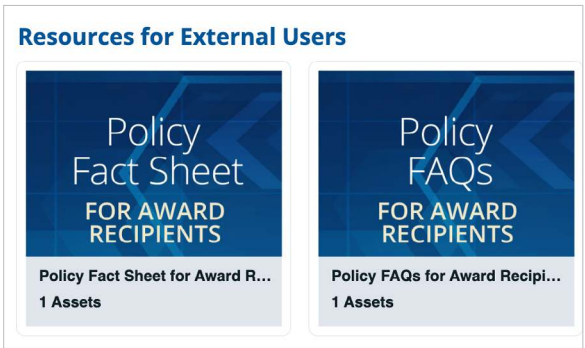
Logo lockup templates

Logo lockups are files that incorporate the NSF logo with another identifier. NSF has standardized the design of official NSF logo lockups, which are available in the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#). NSF also developed a partner [logo lockup template](#) for our MOU partners and predominately (more than 50%) NSF-invested award recipients with awards of \$1 million or more, as an optional resource for convenience. Adobe Illustrator templates and instructions can be found on the portal.

NSF Brand Identity Portal.



Fact Sheets and FAQs on the NSF Brand Identity Portal.



Messaging Requirements

Award recipient acknowledgement messaging requirements

Per the [NSF PAPPG](#), the award recipient must acknowledge NSF in any publication (including webpages) or any other material based on or developed under this award. Additionally, NSF support must be verbally acknowledged during all media interviews including, but not limited to, social media, podcasts, radio, television, film and other publications.

The award recipient is responsible for assuring that every publication of material (including webpages) based on or developed under an NSF investment—except scientific articles or papers appearing in scientific, technical or professional journals—also contains the standard disclaimer and acknowledgement language. This requirement may be waived in instances where the size or type of material produced makes this impractical.

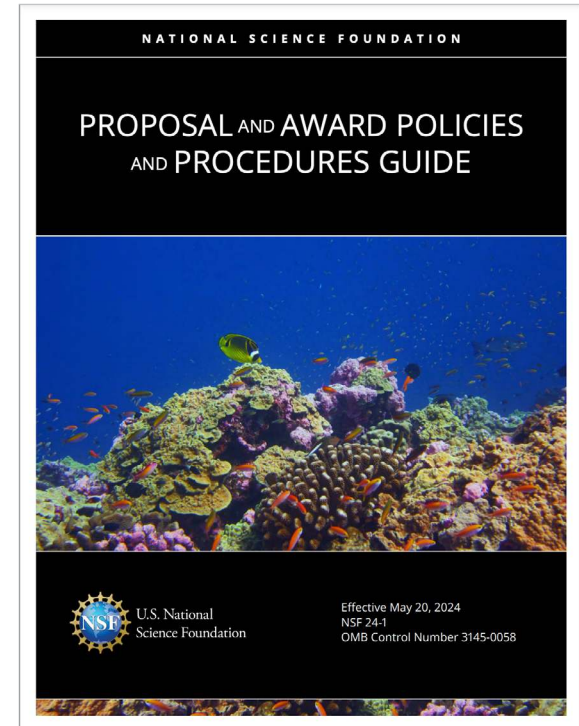
On first reference, reference the agency using “U.S. National Science Foundation” followed by “NSF” on subsequent mentions. Note: “U.S.” should not be included when using the “NSF” acronym and whether to include periods in “U.S.” may be based upon the style preferences of the communicator/publisher.

News releases

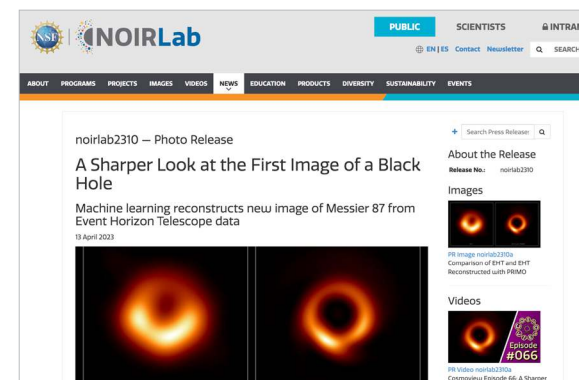
NSF award recipients must work with their PO to keep them informed of their project’s developments to include issuing news releases and related news materials. News releases are required to mention NSF support and include the NSF logo. NSF support must be verbally acknowledged during all news media interviews, including popular media such as radio, television and news magazines.

Award recipients can also request a quote and background information from the cognizant PO at least two weeks in advance. For press releases announcing a new grant, NSF can provide background on the award and the program. For press releases announcing new papers or discoveries, NSF can provide quotes regarding the importance of a finding or breakthrough as appropriate.

NSF Proposal and Award Policies and Procedures Guide.



News release headline highlighting NSF-invested research.



Social Media Requirements

Social media brand application requirements for recipients

Please ensure that all social media requirements for awardees are followed. These depend on funding levels and are defined below:

- **Brand application requirements on social media for predominately (more than 50%) NSF-invested activities with awards of \$1 million or more**

The NSF brand must be implemented on social media channels and accounts of predominantly NSF-invested activities.

Such award recipient names on social media must include “NSF” at the beginning. If the entity has their own logo, they may use it as the main profile image. The NSF logo must not be used as a main profile image since the account is not managed by NSF.

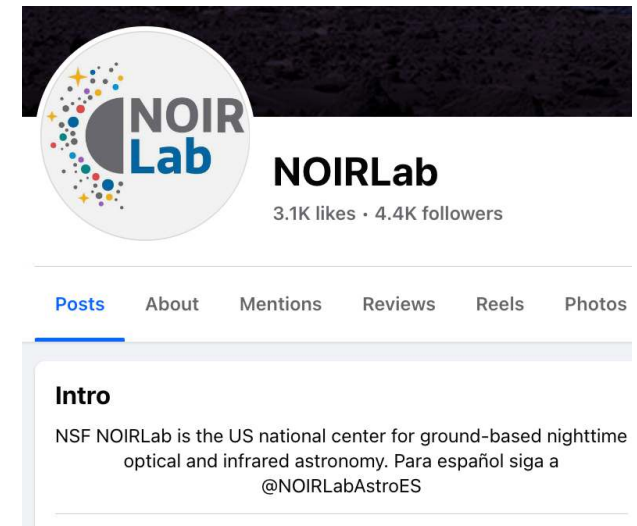
- **The NSF logo must be included on the cover/banner images and all graphic posts related to NSF supported research and activities.**

Additionally, acknowledgment of the relationship with NSF and funding must be included in the profile biography text along with the standard disclaimer from the NSF PAPPG, when possible (See Chapter XI.E.4, Recipient Obligations). *All other brand application requirements as listed in the Brand Application Requirement section still apply here.*

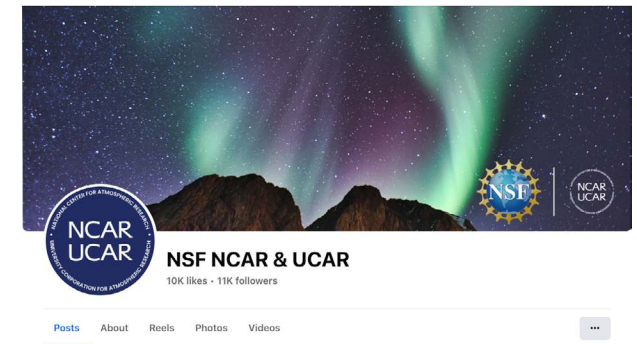
- **Brand application requirements on social media when NSF is majority investor (funds more than any other co-sponsor)**

The NSF logo should be present on graphic posts related to NSF supported research and activities. When feasible, the funding relationship should be acknowledged in the profile biography text.

Mentioning NSF in partner bios with limited spacing.



NSF logo lockup incorporated on the banner image.



Resources for External Users

Social Media Requirements

Sharing news on social media

When sharing exciting news about an NSF award or breakthrough on social media, consider tagging NSF. This helps connect your content to the agency. To tag an NSF account, use the “@” symbol followed by the NSF profile name. Tagging is always preferred but if you can’t, be sure to spell out “U.S. National Science Foundation.”

► X (previously Twitter)

Use [@NSF](#) instead of #NSF when tagging the foundation in your posts. If you are an NSF-invested facility or program, add “[U.S. National Science Foundation](#)” or [#NSFfunded](#) to your X bio.

► Facebook

Use [@National Science Foundation](#) to tag NSF on your post.

► Instagram

Tag NSF’s official Instagram account, [@nsfgov](#), in your posts or stories.

► LinkedIn

Tag [@National Science Foundation \(NSF\)](#) on LinkedIn to highlight your professional accomplishments with the agency, research news or program highlights.

When posting about NSF-invested activities, tag the appropriate NSF social media account and/or use NSF’s official hashtags: [#NSFfunded](#) or [#NSFstories](#). A hashtag uses the “#” symbol to connect keywords together in one place. Use the hashtag [#NSFfunded](#) to post about NSF-invested activities; and [#NSFstories](#) when posting about the individual’s experience that was made possible by NSF. Properly tagging the agency’s social media accounts and including an official hashtag increases visibility and the chance of NSF resharing your content. [Altering the NSF logo or adding the NSF logo as your social media profile photo is prohibited](#). Instead, add the logo to your graphics following the logo guidelines.

Do not imply through posts or profile information that your account officially represents NSF. If possible, highlight the essential role NSF played in making the research possible—go beyond just noting the research was NSF-invested.

Across all social media platforms, refrain from adding new hashtags without first consulting with NSF OLPA. [For social media-related inquiries, email \[SocialMedia@nsf.gov\]\(mailto:SocialMedia@nsf.gov\)](#).

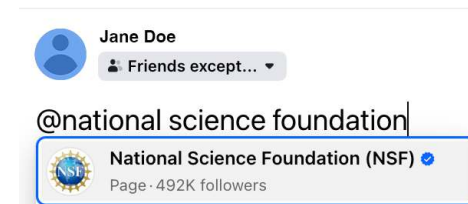
Tagging NSF in a social post.



Mentioning NSF with tagging and hashtags on X.



Tagging NSF on Facebook.



Resources for External Users

Media Hub

NSF Media Hub

The NSF Media Hub is a vast and ever-growing collection of digital assets—a collaborative space for imagery, logos, graphics and templates that can be made available to internal and external users. This is where the [***NSF Brand Identity Portal***](#) is hosted.

Content utilization

Design teams and communicators across NSF use content uploaded by NSF recipients to develop communication materials which spotlight impactful research and the important work being done across all of NSF. Fantastic images related to NSF-invested activities are also highlighted by NSF social media channels. Images must be credited with “U.S. National Science Foundation” and the artist’s name as appropriate, and the ***credit must travel with the image if it is syndicated or otherwise picked up by other parties.***

Portals

Portals are a great way to share and organize images. They provide a secure way to share NSF assets with external users and can be password-protected to distribute embargoed assets securely. Portals can track viewer activity and locations to provide powerful metrics and insights.

Uploading images to the NSF Media Hub (external users)

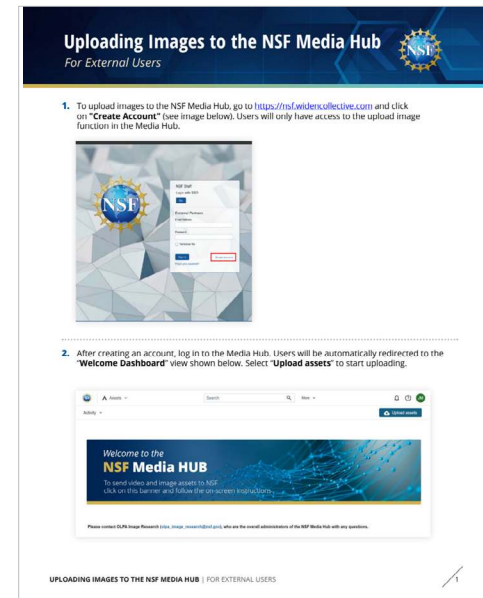
NSF highly encourages uploading imagery to the NSF Media Hub and has created an [***External User Guide***](#) to explain the process. Images provided to NSF may be highlighted in social media, outreach publications or documents. Contact [***olpa_image_research@nsf.gov***](mailto:olpa_image_research@nsf.gov) with any additional questions or for more details.

Users will be asked to add metadata to make the upload process seamless. ***The requested fields are: Caption, Credit, Title (if applicable), a field to denote who the assets are for in NSF and a checkbox that gives NSF permission to use the assets.***

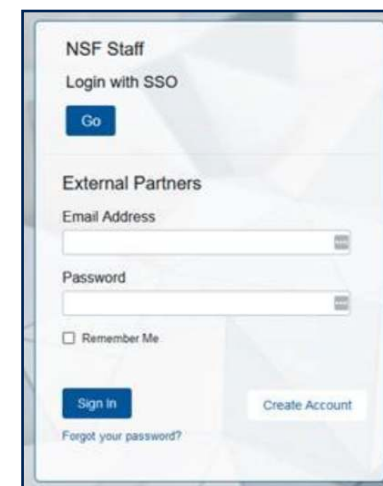
The [***NSF OLPA Image Research***](#) team will be notified of the new assets via email and will let users know they are available in the Media Hub admin dashboard.

Visit [***https://nsf.widencollective.com***](https://nsf.widencollective.com) to create an account, as shown on the lower right.

NSF Media Hub User Guide.



NSF Media Hub login window for external users.



Resources for External Users

Media Outreach & Press Releases

Messaging in media outreach

Award recipients, former recipients and other recipients of NSF funding are among the agency's most effective ambassadors. Continue to share successes (e.g., stories, images and videos) with NSF to help maximize awareness of NSF to the public.

The [*NSF PAPPG*](#) provides guidance on how to include NSF in media outreach.

NSF support **must** be verbally acknowledged during all news media interviews, including in popular media such as radio, television and news magazines. Grants for projects which appear to be of special interest to the general public may be made the subject of an NSF or joint NSF-grantee press release to the news media.

When drafting a press release on an award, the publication of a paper or a discovery, make sure to inform the program manager of the associated NSF award. NSF does not require review and approval prior to publication, except in the case of a joint release with the agency, but always appreciates advance notice. NSF is pleased to provide materials to support press releases published by supported institutions. Those materials can include background language on a program or award portfolio, statistics or a quote from an NSF official talking about the importance of the research. To obtain those materials, email the appropriate program manager listed on an award.

Press releases

When issuing a press release that includes a logo for your institution, contact NSFbranding@nsf.gov for guidance on the proper use of the NSF logo.

Referencing NSF

As there are other organizations with the same initials, write out "U.S. National Science Foundation" on the first reference in all publications and outreach.



Media Interviews

Verbal and written interviews

In verbal or written interviews, the following are suggested approaches: Illustrate how an NSF award provided access to resources, equipment or collaborators that otherwise would have been beyond reach; discuss how the proposal process helped refine the ideas or plans, or the personal pride felt in obtaining research funding from a selective agency such as NSF; or provide details of an award that includes funding for training students or young researchers, or compelling, broader impacts and activities.

► **In your own words, you can address any of the topics below:**

How has NSF impacted you?

What value did NSF provide?

How has NSF supported your research?

Has your NSF-invested research been strengthened by discoveries made through previous NSF-invested research?

How critical is NSF support for basic research (as opposed to other stages of research, where private companies and others might provide support) and for early career researchers?

You can also share quick facts about NSF, like how to apply for funding and impacts the agency has made.

Media reports

NSF endeavors to follow all media reports about the research it funds, but investigators and supported institutions often find reports the agency has missed. If you are aware of media coverage on NSF-invested research, forward it to the appropriate program manager.



Press Clippings

Incorporating NSF into the story

The below statements are examples of ways to include NSF in a press release:

"This _____ would not have been possible without funding and support from the U.S. National Science Foundation."

"U.S. National Science Foundation funding and support including staff and equipment, made this innovative research possible."

"_____ is the recipient of a U.S. National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship, which supports her/his/their research and allowed for participation in this study."

"U.S. National Science Foundation-invested research laid the foundation for _____."

"This research was supported with funding from the U.S. National Science Foundation."

Ways to include NSF in discussions with the media

"We had this unique idea about how to study _____, and NSF gave us the funding to pursue it."

"Thanks to this NSF investment, we were able to discover _____."

"NSF investment in this research led to _____."

Boilerplate

The "About NSF" boilerplate may be added to your press release. The boilerplate is available at the end of any press release posted to [NSF.gov](https://www.nsf.gov):

"The U.S. National Science Foundation (NSF) is an independent federal agency that promotes the progress of science by investing in research to expand knowledge in science, engineering and education across all 50 states and territories. NSF supports nearly 2,000 colleges, universities and other institutions through competitive grants aimed at advancing science with broad impacts across the nation and its people. Learn more at [nsf.gov](https://www.nsf.gov)."



Resources for External Users

Media Advisories

Media Advisory

A *media advisory* alerts members of the media to an open press opportunity.

Media advisories are a short description of a future event, often a call-to-action for journalists. These advisories must always answer the ‘five Ws;’ who, what, when, where, why and how.

Generally, any type of release must include the institution and/or researcher name, award grant information, location and short summary of the project goal. *Contact information to field press questions must be listed as well, for reliability and transparency in communication.*

Please refer to the [NSF.gov/news](https://www.nsf.gov/news) page for examples.

Media advisory template.

FOR PLANNING PURPOSES	date released
Headline that describes the event	
<i>Here is where you can have a few short sentences on what will be happening. Everything should be written in plain language and easily convey the event and purpose. Why should media want to come?</i>	
LOCATION – Place or link for virtual.	
Who: Name, title, organization of participants/presenters	
What: what kind of event, is it a media briefing or a roundtable or something else	
When: Date: Day, MM-DD-YEAR	
Where: address: number, street name, city, state, zip, floor, room and/or link to the virtual location (if applicable).	
RSVP: Here is where you put how reporters can RSVP to the event.	
Include additional information such as if there is an opportunity for interviews, tours or other actions relevant to the event. You can also note other activities occurring relevant to the event.	
For credentialed media only.	



Resources for External Users

News Releases

News releases

A [news release](#) contains information that announces news, informs reporting, and/or tells a story.

News releases must include background information and interviews from experts or key individuals and must succinctly relay facts. Generally, any type of release must include the institution and/or researcher name, award grant information, location and short summary of the project goal.

Contact information to field press questions must be listed as well, for reliability and transparency in communication.

The [Alan T. Waterman](#) announcement is a great example of a news release.

News release template.

The most important information goes up front in a news release! No editorialized opinions unless it is in a quote. Include links where applicable.

Headline: Describes the newsworthy item. Headline should be short and catchy. Attention getting.

First paragraph: The first paragraph is generally one sentence and should provide the most important information up front (who, what, when, where, why how).

Second paragraph: The second paragraph is also generally one sentence and should provide important information that may not have been included in the first paragraph.

Third paragraph/Quote: Insert a quote from a relevant subject matter expert or relevant leadership. Consider a quote that is inspiring and provides information not included elsewhere in the story.

Subsequent paragraphs: These paragraphs can include additional information and/or quotes relevant to the news you are trying to convey. Include the most important information first.

Final paragraph/boilerplate: End with NSF's latest boilerplate template.



Award Recipient Announcements

Award announcement template

A *sample template* is shown in the example to the right. This sample includes all necessary information to list in an external award announcement. It is not a requirement to use this template, but is available if for reference if needed.

Example award announcement (external to NSF).

[ENTER INSTITUTION/RESEARCHER NAME] Awarded [DOLLAR AMOUNT] Grant from the National Science Foundation

Award will allow for [NEW INITIATIVE OR RESEARCH]

[CITY, STATE, DATE] – [INSTITUTION/RESEARCHER NAME] has been awarded a [DOLLAR AMOUNT] National Science Foundation (NSF) grant for research on [SHORT SUMMARY OF PROJECT GOAL].

General paragraph describing the unique aspects of this project, either in terms of its research goals, methods or the team working on it.

“This is where a quote from the principal investigator would typically go,” said [PRINCIPAL INVESTIGATOR NAME], a researcher at your institution. “This is also a good place to talk about potential benefits to society.”

This paragraph can be a good place to talk about the grant in detail, including the NSF program that funded it. NSF can provide information for principal investigators and public information officers, and the PI’s award abstract is also a helpful document. Remember, NSF cannot provide information about proposals, such as how many others had proposals declined or the award rate.

“This is where a quote from an NSF official can go,” said [NSF OFFICIAL], a program manager at NSF. “It’s a great place for NSF to reinforce the importance of this work.”

More detail about the awarded project usually follows in the paragraphs below. If NSF funded anything else associated with the new award, from facilities and equipment to graduate students, NSF would be happy to provide background.

NSF Media Contact: NSF Public Affairs, media@nsf.gov, 703-292-7090
[Note: NSF does not require its media contact listed in releases from funded institutions. However, the agency will take calls responding to media looking for more information about the award or program. Please do not list contact information for other NSF officials, such as a program manager.]



ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

Section 508 Compliance
Frequently Asked Questions
Contact Information
Glossary



Additional Resources

Section 508 Compliance

NSF is committed to making all digitally published content accessible in accordance with Section 508 compliance requirements.

NSF also encourages its award recipients to use the web to disseminate information about their work and to create digital content that is generally accessible for people with disabilities using assistive technologies. More information about accessible web design and additional resources are listed below.

In general, all content must be designed and developed in their native software, such as: Adobe Illustrator; Adobe InDesign; MS Word; or MS PowerPoint with accessibility in mind, and then made compliant as a final PDF deliverable.

See [Section508.gov](https://www.section508.gov) for more information and the most up-to-date 508 compliance rules and regulations. [Learning modules](#) are also available for walkthrough and training.

► Adobe Acrobat

Adobe Acrobat has a built-in tool that aids 508 compliance. This tool highlights errors, explains rules and in some cases shows how to remediate failed items.

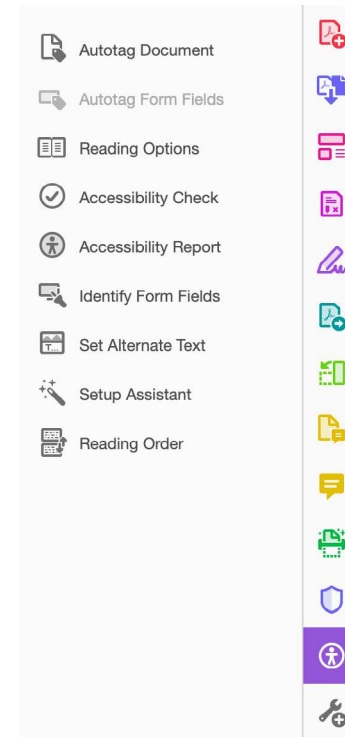
► PowerPoint

PowerPoint has a built-in Section 508 Compliance checker. Staying within the brand application guidelines and checking compliance ensures proper use and readability, which are vital in any NSF-published materials.

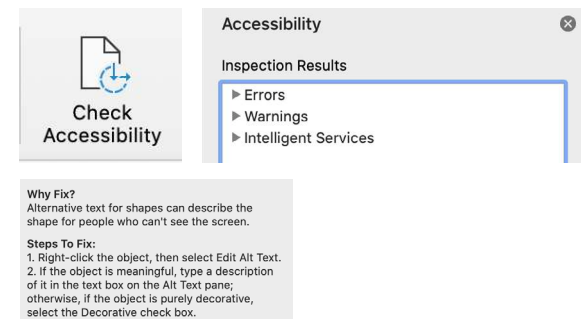
► Online tools

[WebAim](#), [WhoCanUse](#) and [TPGi Color Contrast Checker](#) are free online tools that evaluate color contrast and pass/fail ratios. Webaim goes further in depth and offers paid accessibility training courses.

Adobe Acrobat compliance checker panel.



PowerPoint 508 compliance tool.



Frequently Asked Questions

Where can I download the NSF logo files?

NSF logo files are available for download through the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#).

Who can use the logo?

NSF's logo can be used by recipients of NSF support for the sole purpose of acknowledging that support and as outlined in the [NSF Policy on Brand Standards](#) and the [Using NSF's Logo](#) section of this manual.

Who cannot use the logo?

NSF's logo cannot be used in a manner that falsely implies employment by or affiliation with NSF. NSF's logo cannot be used to imply endorsement of a product or service.

Do I need permission to use the NSF logo?

If you meet the stated requirements listed in the [Using NSF's Logo](#) section for using the NSF logo, no explicit permission is necessary to use the NSF logo. No other potential uses of the NSF logo are permitted unless prior written consent is obtained from the NSF OLPA by contacting NSFbranding@nsf.gov. Reference the [Logo Use by Partners and Others](#) section for instructions on how to submit a request.

Which file should I use?

The file format will make a significant impact on the production quality of the completed material. All available logo files can be sourced from the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#).

► Web use, presentations and other electronic uses:

For the lowest resolution and smallest file size, use the low-resolution PNG format. For a higher resolution graphic, use the high-resolution PNG format.

► Print use, large-format or special needs:

Use the EPS vector file. For more details, see the [Logo Files](#) section.



Additional Resources

Frequently Asked Questions

Who can I contact for more information on the NSF brand identity?

For questions regarding use of NSF's brand identity or additional resource needs, email NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

Do you have additional resources for NSF staff?

NSF OLPA has developed the [NSF Brand Identity Portal](#) for NSF staff to easily source templates, logos, iconography and more. The [Resources for NSF Staff](#) section contains a multitude of information to aid NSF staff in brand application. Contact NSF Brand Management with any questions at NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

Contact Information

NSF OLPA manages the U.S. National Science Foundation brand for the agency. Questions regarding appropriate logo use and other brand inquiries may be submitted to NSFbranding@nsf.gov.

- ▶ **Photography** image needs and copyright and permissions questions: olpa_image_research@nsf.gov.
- ▶ **Brand identity** questions and other inquiries: NSFbranding@nsf.gov.
- ▶ **Communications** planning with NSF OLPA Creative Services: OlpaDigitalEngage@nsf.gov.
- ▶ **Social media** questions: SocialMedia@nsf.gov.
- ▶ **NSF Media** questions: Media@nsf.gov.



Glossary

Brand

Brand refers to a distinct identity created for an entity to shape the perceptions of those who interact with it. It is a strategic and intentional way to differentiate an entity from others.

Brand application

Brand application refers to how an entity's brand is used and implemented across all communications. It is vital to create a unified, cohesive voice and visual consistency when interacting with an audience to establish brand recognition.

Brand clearance

Brand clearance is NSF's review process for long-term, resource-intensive products such as webpages, signage and exhibit displays, instrumentation and equipment marking, outreach products, swag and other promotional items to ensure that the NSF brand is applied in accordance with our brand standards and is reproduced by vendors accurately.

Brand elements

An entity's name, logo, tagline, color palette, font, images etc. are referred to as brand elements. They are reflected in every communication put forth by the entity.

Brand identity

A brand's identity consists of elements of visual identity like logo, color palette, typography, voice and tone. Strong brand recognition is dependent upon a well-defined brand identity.

Boilerplate

A boilerplate is standardized copy used at the end of written content to provide agency information and history.

Clear space

The amount of free, undisturbed space on each side of a graphic, image or logo.

Color palette

A designated set of colors to represent the entity to create a brand personality and awareness. A brand's color palette can be inspired by and reflect the mission and values of the entity. All visual assets like print materials, website, internal and external communications should align with the designated color palette.

Communications

Tactics, such as informational and promotional content, multimedia and social media, that are used to share information.

Communication design treatments

Communication design treatments are thematic designs for campaigns, announcements and events that incorporate the NSF brand identity elements and standards. These thematic treatments should be retired after the conclusion of its original purpose.

Contrast

Contrast is the difference in luminance or color that makes an object visible on a background of different luminance or color.

Logo

A symbolic representation of an entity conveyed via the use of unique typography and/or iconography. Logos are a key component to a brand's visual identity and is inspired by the entity's unique mission statement and values.

Logo lockups

A final form of a logo complete with all the elements such as typography, icons, taglines and other variants. This unique arrangement of elements is not to be altered in any way. NSF's official logo lockups combine the logo with text of the agency's name or sub-entities such as directorates and offices in a standardized way. Logo lockups can also be used to pair the NSF logo with those of award recipients predominately supported by NSF or with partner logos, when appropriate.



Additional Resources

Glossary

Naming conventions

An agreed-upon standard for naming things. This could be any form of arrangement of variables that allows for easy iteration.

NSF-invested

Used synonymously with NSF-supported or NSF-funded, this language focuses on the fact that NSF's role in these projects is an investment, furthering understanding of NSF's commitment to these activities as part of its mission.

Physical marking

A logo used on non-digital, tangible materials, products and property.

Raster file

A raster file is an image file, built with pixels, that has a maximum sizing based on resolution.

Thematic design treatments

Thematic design treatments are a way to create a cohesive look and feel across communication materials for a particular campaign, announcement, event, etc. These are not intended to be used as a logo or long-term representation of a specific office or program.

Vector file

A vector file contains scalable graphics that will maintain resolution and clarity when increased or decreased in size, typically used in print and large-format scenarios.

Vendor proof

An example provided by a third party production company to show what a final, finished product will look like (prior to approval and production).

